

Digital Sales School

A competency-based career school that trains, assesses and certifies digital sales professionals: people who can sell AI, SaaS, software, apps, cybersecurity and other technology solutions, for employers in Nigeria and abroad.

Learn to sell technology. Build a career in revenue.

Find Right market, right account	Start Open a real conversation	Qualify Confirm a real opportunity	Discover Understand the problem	Present Connect product to need	Demonstrate Show it in context	Handle Work through concerns	Close Convert to customer	Grow Retain and expand
Setter / SDR track owns this				Closer / AE track owns this				

This is the DSS Digital Revenue Journey. Every module in this manual is tied to one stage of that line. If a lesson does not help a student move a technology opportunity from one stage to the next, it does not belong in the programme.

1. Programme overview

Most sales training available in Nigeria today teaches generic persuasion: how to talk to anyone about anything. That approach is running out of road. The World Bank's 2025 review of nearly five million online job postings across Nigeria, Kenya, South Africa and Uganda found that close to half required at least one digital skill, and that communication and problem-solving remained consistently in demand alongside it. Digital sales sits exactly on that intersection, and almost nobody in the Nigerian training market is teaching it as its own discipline.

Every technology company, from a two-person automation studio to a global SaaS platform, creates something that still has to be sold. Someone has to answer who needs it, why they need it, how to reach them, how to prove the value, and how to turn interest into a signed deal. That person is a digital sales professional. Digital Sales School (DSS) exists to train that specific professional, on purpose, at a standard employers can verify.

DSS does not train people to "sell." It trains people to operate the commercial side of a technology business: prospecting, qualifying, discovering, demonstrating, handling objections, closing and managing a pipeline, for AI, SaaS, software, apps, cybersecurity, cloud, fintech and automation products specifically.

The gap this closes

Three gaps sit behind this programme, and each one shapes a real design decision in the curriculum that follows.

The education gap

People learn to build technology. Almost nobody teaches them to commercialise it. A student can code, design or run AI tools and still have no idea how to turn that capability into revenue for an employer.

The employability gap

A certificate of attendance proves nothing. Employers need evidence: can this person actually prospect, qualify, run discovery, demonstrate a product, handle objections, and close, on a technology sale specifically. DSS is built to produce evidence, not attendance records.

The perception gap

Say "sales job" in Nigeria and most people picture door-to-door persuasion. DSS is explicit from day one: this is the commercial practice of taking AI, SaaS, software and technology solutions to market, using data, modern communication channels and AI tools. That is a different career, and it has to be taught and marketed as one.

The DSS definition

Digital sales is the professional practice of using technology, data, modern communication and AI to generate, develop and convert business opportunities into revenue for technology products and services.

That sentence is the programme's intellectual territory. Every module, case study and assessment in this manual exists to make a student capable of that definition, not just able to recite it.

2. Who it is for, and what they leave with

DSS does not target everybody. It targets people who want a career in the commercial side of technology without becoming programmers. Six segments make up the addressable audience; instructors should be able to place any applicant into one of them during admission screening.

Segment	Who they are	What DSS gives them
Young professionals	Asking what digital skill actually leads to a career, with no clear entry point yet.	A defined, teachable skill and a credential employers can check.
Graduates	Have a degree, limited practical commercial experience.	A portfolio of real work: campaigns, calls, a closed simulated deal, not just a transcript.
Career switchers	Want into technology without learning to code.	A credible non-technical route into the technology sector.
Existing salespeople	Already selling, want to move into SaaS, AI or B2B technology sales specifically.	Technology literacy and a technology-specific sales methodology layered on existing instinct.
Entrepreneurs and founders	Building their own technology product, need to sell it themselves.	A repeatable system for their own pipeline, not dependence on a hired salesperson.
Freelancers and service providers	Can deliver the work, struggle to acquire clients consistently.	A structured, non-random way to generate and convert opportunities.

What a graduate can say, on completion

By the end of the programme a graduate should be able to make every one of the following statements honestly, and defend each one with a portfolio artifact:

- I can identify a target market and build a real prospect list.
- I can research an account and a decision-maker before ever reaching out.
- I can open a professional conversation across LinkedIn, email, WhatsApp and phone.
- I can qualify an opportunity honestly, using real criteria, not hope.
- I can run a discovery conversation that surfaces the real problem and its cost.
- I can demonstrate a technology product against a specific business outcome, not a feature list.

- I can translate a feature into business value and financial impact.
- I can handle an objection without arguing.
- I can negotiate and close a qualified opportunity.
- I can manage a CRM pipeline and read my own numbers.
- I can use AI throughout the sales process, and I know exactly where I am not allowed to let it speak for me unchecked.

DSS does not promise a job. It promises this: by graduation, a student can compete for one, with evidence, not just a claim.

3. The Digital Revenue Journey

DSS is built around a single proprietary framework rather than a list of unrelated topics. The Digital Revenue Journey is the nine-stage path a technology opportunity travels from first contact to renewed revenue. It is the pipeline diagram in the hero of this document, and it is the spine every module attaches to.

Stage	What happens	Owned by
Find	Identify the right market, the right accounts, and the right people inside them.	Setter / SDR
Start	Open a real, specific, channel-appropriate conversation.	Setter / SDR
Qualify	Confirm a genuine opportunity exists: fit, need, authority, timeline.	Setter / SDR
Discover	Understand the customer's actual situation, problem and its cost.	Setter / SDR, deepened by Closer
Present	Connect the product to what discovery actually surfaced.	Closer / AE
Demonstrate	Show the product working against the customer's own outcome.	Closer / AE
Handle	Work through concerns and objections without losing the deal or the relationship.	Closer / AE

Close	Convert a qualified opportunity into a signed customer.	Closer / AE
Grow	Retain, expand and turn the account into a reference.	Closer / AE, later Revenue Operator

Two things make this framework different from the eight-stage pipeline used in DSS's earlier general-sales edition of this programme. First, Present and Demonstrate are split into two distinct stages, because showing a technology product working is a different skill from explaining what it does, and technology buyers specifically expect both. Second, the journey ends at Grow, not at Won, because a technology sale that renews is worth more than one that does not, and a graduate who only knows how to close a first deal is only half-trained for a real revenue role.

4. Competency framework: the DSS Sales Readiness Index

DSS assesses students against ten weighted competencies, not attendance. This scorecard, the DSS Sales Readiness Index, is what a graduate can eventually hand an employer alongside a CV: a specific, numeric profile instead of a vague claim of experience.

Competency	Weight	What it actually measures
Technology literacy	10%	Can explain what a SaaS, AI, cloud, cybersecurity or fintech product does and who it helps, without engineering jargon.
Prospecting	10%	Can build a real, researched target account and contact list from scratch.
Communication	10%	Writes and speaks in a way that earns a reply, across four channels.
Qualification	10%	Confirms fit, need, authority and timeline honestly, without stage inflation.
Discovery	15%	Surfaces the customer's real problem and its cost, not just the stated symptom.
Product demonstration	10%	Shows a product against a specific outcome, live, without narrating a feature list.

Value selling	10%	Translates a feature into business value and financial impact on demand.
Objection handling	10%	Resolves a real concern without arguing or discounting reflexively.
Closing	10%	Asks for the decision clearly and manages a technology buying process.
CRM and AI operations	5%	Runs a clean pipeline and uses AI tools productively and accountably.

Discovery carries the heaviest single weight, deliberately. A technology sale that skips discovery becomes a features demo nobody asked for, which is the single most common failure this programme is built to prevent.

A graduating score is reported exactly like a real assessment, for example: **DSS Sales Readiness Score: 82/100**, with the ten-competency breakdown attached. This is the artifact described in section 16, and it is designed to be more useful to an employer than thirty unranked CVs.

5. Curriculum map

Twenty-eight modules, grouped into seven parts, delivered over a 13-week core programme with an optional Sales Lab capstone extension. Every part is tied to a specific stretch of the Digital Revenue Journey.

Part	Weeks	Modules	Digital Revenue Journey focus
1. Digital economy & technology literacy	1–2	1–5	Foundation, before Find
2. Customer intelligence & AI prospecting	3–4	6–9	Find
3. Pipeline creation (setter track)	5–6	10–14	Start, Qualify
	7–8	15–18	Discover, Present, Demonstrate

4. Discovery, demo & value (closer track)			
5. Objections, closing & negotiation	9–10	19–21	Handle, Close
6. Revenue & AI operations	11–12	22–25	Grow, and the pipeline as a whole
7. Sales Lab, portfolio & deployment	13+	26–28	Full journey, simulated end to end

Students are assigned a primary track (Setter or Closer) at the end of Week 6, based on a scored checkpoint. Both tracks complete Parts 1, 2 and 6 together; Parts 3 and 4 are where the tracks specialise.

6. Weekly delivery model

Each teaching week runs as one structured three-hour session, live or synchronous online, followed by independent practice using the student manual and the Sales Lab environment.

Segment	Duration	What happens
Concept	45 min	Instructor-led teaching of the week's key concepts, grounded in a real technology business case study.
Demonstration	30 min	Instructor runs the week's skill live: a call, a demo, an objection sequence, a CRM audit.
Guided practical	60 min	Students run the step-by-step practical from the module's lesson note, in pairs or small groups.
Role-play lab	30 min	Scenario-based practice against a partner or the AI role-play engine, scored against the week's competency.
Debrief	15 min	Common mistakes, the following week's preview, and portfolio artifact logging.

Part 1 · The digital economy & technology literacy

Weeks 1–2 | Modules 1–5 | Before Find on the Digital Revenue Journey

Before a student contacts a single prospect, they need two things most sales training skips entirely: an honest picture of what this job actually is, and enough technology literacy to talk credibly about a product they did not build. Part 1 delivers both, plus the ethical standard the rest of the programme is built on.

Week 1 · What this job is, and the world it sells into

Modules 1–3

Module 1 · What digital sales actually is

Digital Revenue Journey: foundation · 3 hours

Destroys the "salesman knocking on doors" image before it can take root. Reframes selling as the commercial function that connects a technology product to the business that needs it. Introduces the Digital Revenue Journey as the spine of the entire programme.

Key concepts: digital sales as a professional discipline; activity versus revenue; the four states of a technology opportunity (lead, prospect, opportunity, customer).

Module 2 · The digital economy map

Foundation · 3 hours

A guided tour of what DSS graduates will actually be selling: SaaS, AI products, mobile apps, cybersecurity, cloud infrastructure, fintech, automation and technology hardware. Covers the business models behind each (subscription, usage-based, one-time licence, marketplace) and why the model changes how the sale is run.

Key concepts: B2B versus B2C technology sales; recurring revenue versus one-time sale; where digital sales sits inside a technology company.

Module 3 · Technology literacy I: SaaS & AI

Foundation · 3 hours

Students do not need to become engineers. They need enough working knowledge of SaaS and AI products to ask an intelligent question and understand the answer. Covers common SaaS categories, what "AI-powered" claims actually tend to mean in a product, and the questions a buyer will expect a credible salesperson to be able to answer.

Key concepts: subscription economics (MRR, ARR, churn); what an AI feature actually does under the hood, at a commercial level; credibility without jargon.

Week 2 · The rest of the stack, and the standard

Modules 4–5

Module 4 · Technology literacy II: cloud, cybersecurity, fintech & automation

Foundation · 3 hours

Continues the technology literacy work into four more categories DSS graduates will encounter: cloud infrastructure, cybersecurity, fintech and business automation. Same method as Module 3: what the category solves, common objections buyers raise in that category specifically, and the vocabulary a credible seller uses.

Module 5 · Ethics & the DSS professional standard

Foundation · 3 hours · charter signed at close

Taught in Week 2, not at the end of the programme, because habits form before the lecture lands. Covers the manager test, stage inflation, and the specific ethical traps of technology sales: overclaiming security posture, overstating AI capability, and promising integration timelines nobody has confirmed. Students sign the DSS professional charter before Part 2 begins.

Part 2 · Customer intelligence & AI-powered prospecting

Weeks 3–4 | Modules 6–9 | Digital Revenue Journey: Find

Before a student contacts anyone, they need to know exactly who to contact and why. Part 2 builds the research discipline that separates a targeted, credible outreach campaign from a spray of generic messages, and introduces AI as the research and personalisation engine behind it.

Week 3 · Knowing the customer before you speak to them

Modules 6–7

Module 6 · Customer intelligence: ICP, persona & decision-maker mapping

Find · 3 hours

Introduces the Ideal Customer Profile (ICP) and buyer persona as working tools, not theory. Students learn to map a real buying committee for a technology purchase: who has the pain, who has the budget, who has the authority to sign, and who can block the deal even without formal authority.

Key concepts: ICP; buyer persona; decision-maker versus influencer versus blocker; the principle that you cannot sell effectively to someone you do not understand.

Module 7 · Why technology buyers actually buy

Find · 3 hours

Adapts the universal buying-drivers lesson to a B2B technology context specifically: risk reduction, competitive pressure, compliance and audit requirements, cost reduction, and the fear of being left behind by a competitor who already adopted the technology. Status quo bias is taught as the real competitor in most technology deals, not the rival vendor.

Week 4 · AI as the research and outreach engine

Modules 8–9

Module 8 · AI-powered prospecting

Find · 3 hours · signature DSS module

Students learn to use AI tools to research target companies, identify likely decision-makers, segment a list by fit, and draft personalised first-touch messages at a volume that would be impossible by hand, while keeping every claim about the prospect verified before it is sent. This is where the accountability rule from Module 24 is first introduced.

Key concepts: AI-assisted account research; segmentation at scale; personalisation without fabrication; the human verification step before any AI-drafted claim goes to a real buyer.

Module 9 · Building a multi-channel outbound sequence

Find, into Start · 3 hours

Turns the researched list from Module 8 into an actual outreach campaign across LinkedIn, email and, where appropriate, WhatsApp: a sequenced, multi-touch system rather than a single message and a hope.

Part 3 · Pipeline creation (Setter / SDR track)

Weeks 5–6 | Modules 10–14 | Digital Revenue Journey: Start, Qualify

Track assignment happens at the end of Week 6. Every student completes Part 3 regardless of eventual track, because even a future Closer needs to understand exactly what a Setter hands them and why. Students who continue on the Setter track will use this part's skills as their day-to-day job.

Week 5 · Opening the conversation and qualifying it honestly

Modules 10–12

Module 10 · The setter's job & pipeline KPIs

Start · 3 hours

Defines the setter's job as pipeline creation, not "calling people." Introduces the nine metrics setters are measured on and the discipline of diagnosing the weakest rate before increasing volume.

Module 11 · The first response & channel mastery for tech buyers

Start · 3 hours

Speed and relevance in the first reply, adapted specifically to how technology buyers behave on LinkedIn and email versus how a Nigerian SME buyer behaves on WhatsApp. Covers the etiquette differences that mark a message as credible or as spam.

Module 12 · Qualification for technology sales

Qualify · 3 hours

A technology-specific qualification framework built on Fit, Need, Authority and Timeline, sequenced to establish a real problem and its cost before budget is ever discussed. Includes the specific technology-sales qualifiers: current tooling, integration constraints, and procurement process.

Week 6 · Booking the meeting and handing it off

Modules 13–14 · track assignment at close

Module 13 · Appointment setting & show-rate systems

Qualify, into Discover · 3 hours

The framing paragraph, the two-named-times booking ask, and the four-message show-up sequence that moves show rates from roughly a third to close to four in five, applied to demo and discovery-call booking specifically.

Module 14 · The handoff to a closer

Discover · 3 hours · track assignment

The full handoff format and the three-question test. Closes with the scored Week 6 checkpoint that assigns each student to the Setter or Closer track for Parts 3 and 4's specialisation, based on demonstrated strength, not preference alone.

Part 4 · Discovery, demo & value (Closer / AE track)

Weeks 7–8 | Modules 15–18 | Digital Revenue Journey: Discover, Present, Demonstrate

This is where a technology sale is genuinely won or lost. Students on the Closer track go deep here; Setter-track students complete a condensed version so they understand exactly what happens after their handoff.

Week 7 · Understanding the problem before showing anything

Modules 15–16

Module 15 · Discovery for technology sales

Discover · 3 hours · heaviest-weighted competency

The Situation, Problem, Impact, Desired Outcome, Solution Fit sequence. Trains students to stay in one area of enquiry past the first, comfortable answer until it becomes something concrete enough to build a recommendation on. The single most heavily weighted competency in the DSS Sales Readiness Index.

Module 16 · Product demonstration: demo the outcome, not the feature

Present, into Demonstrate · 3 hours

The core discipline of technology sales demos: never open with a button, always open with the specific business outcome discovery surfaced. Students run a live demo of a real or simulated SaaS product, judged on whether it connects to the buyer's stated problem within the first ninety seconds.

Week 8 · Translating features into money

Modules 17–18

Module 17 · Value selling: feature to financial impact

Present · 3 hours

The Feature → Capability → Business Value → Financial Impact ladder. Students practise climbing it for real technology features until landing on a concrete number or outcome becomes automatic rather than effortful.

Module 18 · Presenting & pricing a technology solution

Present, into Handle · 3 hours

The eight-step presentation structure applied to SaaS and technology pricing specifically: tiered pricing, seat-based pricing, usage-based pricing, and the silence discipline after stating a number.

Part 5 · Objections, closing & negotiation

Weeks 9–10 | Modules 19–21 | Digital Revenue Journey: Handle, Close

Week 9 · Working through resistance

Modules 19–20

Module 19 · Objection handling for technology buyers

Handle · 3 hours

The five-step objection method applied to the objections technology buyers raise specifically: "we already built something like this internally," "how do we know our data is safe," "we're locked into a competitor's contract," and "who else is using this at our scale."

Module 20 · Closing technology deals

Close · 3 hours

Buying signals, procurement processes, security reviews, proof-of-concept and pilot structures, and the closes that actually apply to a multi-stakeholder technology purchase rather than a single-buyer transaction.

Week 10 · Getting to a fair, closed number

Module 21

Module 21 · Negotiation

Close · 3 hours

Anchoring, trading instead of discounting, and structuring payment terms around a buyer's real constraint, taught against realistic SaaS contract and annual-licence scenarios.

Part 6 · Revenue & AI operations

Weeks 11–12 | Modules 22–25 | Digital Revenue Journey: Grow, and the full pipeline

Both tracks rejoin here. This part turns a student who can run one good conversation into someone who can operate and improve an entire revenue pipeline, and who uses AI as a working tool rather than an unsupervised replacement.

Week 11 · Running the pipeline like an operator

Modules 22–23

Module 22 · CRM & pipeline management for technology sales

Grow, whole pipeline · 3 hours

Clean record discipline across a technology-sales pipeline: lead, contacted, engaged, qualified, meeting, opportunity, proposal, negotiation, won or lost, with the entry conditions for each stage enforced.

Module 23 · Sales analytics & forecasting

Whole pipeline · 3 hours

Reading conversion rates across the full Digital Revenue Journey, diagnosing the weakest stage, and forecasting revenue from a live pipeline rather than guessing.

Week 12 · AI as a working tool, with a hard accountability rule

Modules 24–25

Module 24 · AI sales operations

Whole pipeline · 3 hours · accountability rule taught here

AI before the call (research), during preparation (strategy and questions), after the call (summarisation), in follow-up (personalised drafts), and in practice (the AI role-play engine). Anchored by one non-negotiable rule: AI output never reaches a real buyer unread and unverified by the human who is accountable for it.

Module 25 · Revenue leak recovery

Grow · 3 hours

Finding and recovering leaking pipeline value: uncontacted leads, stalled deals, churned accounts that were never properly exited, and renewal dates nobody tracked. Uses the DSS simulated pipeline audit dataset.

Part 7 · The Sales Lab, portfolio & deployment

Week 13 onward | Modules 26–28 | The full Digital Revenue Journey, simulated end to end

Module 26 · The DSS Sales Lab: full simulation

Full journey · capstone

Students run the complete Digital Revenue Journey against a fictional technology company (see section 15), from first prospect to a simulated closed deal, assessed against every competency in the Readiness Index at once.

Module 27 · Building your portfolio & DSS certification

Deployment prep

Assembling the eleven-piece graduate portfolio and sitting the ten-part DSS certification described in section 14.

Module 28 · Career tracks & getting deployed

Deployment

Choosing a specialisation track, building a technology-sales CV and LinkedIn profile, and the realistic routes into a first paid role, covered in full in section 17.

7. Full lesson notes

Every module in Part 1 through Part 7 is taught using the complete format below. Module 1 is written out in full here as the worked model. The remaining twenty-seven follow immediately as the next build phase of this manual, using the identical structure and the same depth: key concepts, a step-by-step classroom practical, a business case study, a hands-on exercise, a mini challenge, a knowledge check, and instructor notes.

Module 1 · What digital sales actually is

Lesson title

What digital sales actually is: the commercial half of every technology company

Lesson overview

Students arrive with one of two pictures of "sales": door-to-door persuasion, or a vague sense that it means being talkative and confident. Neither picture survives this lesson. Students leave understanding digital sales as a specific, learnable, professional discipline: the practice of connecting a technology product to the business that needs it, using research, structured conversation and honest qualification, not charm.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Define digital sales in one sentence, without using the word "convince."
2. Name the nine stages of the DSS Digital Revenue Journey in order.
3. Explain the difference between a lead, a prospect, an opportunity and a customer, for a technology product specifically.
4. Explain why activity (messages sent, calls made) is not the same as progress (opportunities moved toward revenue).
5. State, credibly, what kind of company and role they are training to work in.

Real-world motivation

Ask the class: when you hear "sales job," what do you picture? Let several students answer honestly, most will describe door-to-door selling or a market stall. Then ask: who do you think decides which SaaS tool a Nigerian bank actually buys, out of the dozens that pitch it every year? Somebody has to research that bank, understand its problem, get in front of the right person, prove the product works for them specifically, and close a contract that might be worth tens of millions of naira a year. That person is not standing outside a shop. They are a digital sales professional, and it is a completely different job from the picture the class just described.

Key concepts

Concept 1: Digital sales, defined precisely

Definition. The professional practice of using technology, data, modern communication and AI to generate, develop and convert business opportunities into revenue for technology products and services.

Simple explanation. Someone builds the software. Someone else has to find the business that needs it, prove it solves their problem, and get them to pay for it. That second person is doing digital sales.

Why it matters. Every word in the definition is doing work. "Generate" means this job creates opportunities, it does not wait for them. "Convert" means the job is measured by revenue, not conversation. Students who lose sight of either half drift into two common failure modes this whole programme is built to prevent: all activity and no revenue, or a great relationship that never actually closes.

Concept 2: The Digital Revenue Journey

Definition. The nine-stage path a technology opportunity travels: Find, Start, Qualify, Discover, Present, Demonstrate, Handle, Close, Grow.

Simple explanation. This is the map for the entire programme. Every module the class will take is training for one specific stage of this journey. A student who can name all nine, in order, already understands the shape of the whole course.

Concept 3: Lead, prospect, opportunity, customer

Definition. Four increasingly qualified states a contact moves through, each requiring real evidence, not optimism, to advance.

Simple explanation. A lead is a name with contact information. A prospect has responded and shown some relevance. An opportunity has a confirmed problem, budget authority and a realistic timeline. A customer has paid. Calling someone a customer before they have paid is not enthusiasm, it is a data error that will mislead every report built on top of it.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will classify a mixed list of fifteen real-style technology-sales contacts into the correct one of the four states, and explain their reasoning for each.

Requirements

- A list of fifteen contact scenarios, provided by the instructor, covering a mix of SaaS, AI and cybersecurity contexts

- A classification worksheet with columns for contact, current state, and evidence

Step 1 · Read all fifteen scenarios once, without classifying

Students get a general sense of the range before making any judgement.

Step 2 · Classify each contact into one of the four states

Working individually, students assign lead, prospect, opportunity or customer to each of the fifteen.

Step 3 · Write one line of evidence per classification

For each contact, students must cite the specific detail in the scenario that justifies the state, not a general impression.

Step 4 · Compare classifications in pairs

Pairs compare all fifteen and mark every disagreement.

Step 5 · Resolve every disagreement against the definitions

For each disagreement, pairs re-read the relevant definition from Concept 3 and agree a final classification with evidence.

Testing

How to check the work: every "opportunity" classification must show evidence of a confirmed problem, budget authority and a realistic timeline. Any opportunity missing one of the three should be downgraded to prospect.

Expected result: a completed worksheet with all fifteen contacts classified and justified, and a visibly smaller "opportunity" count than most students guess at the start.

Common errors: classifying a friendly, responsive contact as an opportunity without confirmed budget or authority; classifying a contact as a customer based on verbal interest rather than actual payment.

Final output

A completed, evidence-backed classification worksheet, kept as the student's first reference example for pipeline discipline later in the programme.

Reflection

- How many contacts did you initially over-classify, and in which direction?
- What was the most common missing piece of evidence for a downgraded "opportunity"?

- How would a business owner's decisions change if these fifteen contacts were mislabelled in a real CRM?

Business case study · a Lagos AI automation studio's confused pipeline

Problem. A small Lagos-based AI automation studio, selling workflow automation to mid-size businesses, believed it had eighteen active opportunities worth a combined ₦54m.

Current manual process. Any company that had replied positively to an outreach message was logged as an "opportunity" in a spreadsheet, regardless of whether budget or a real decision-maker had ever been confirmed.

What the process is actually costing. When audited against real evidence, only five of the eighteen had a confirmed budget holder and a real timeline. The founder had been planning hiring and cash flow around a pipeline number that was more than three times the honest figure.

The fix taught in this course. Reclassifying all eighteen using the four-state definitions, with evidence required for every "opportunity" label.

Estimated time saved. Avoided a premature hiring decision based on inflated pipeline value.

Estimated revenue recovered. Sales effort redirected from thirteen unqualified contacts toward the five real opportunities, improving close rate on the pipeline that actually existed.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Apply the four-state classification to a real or realistic technology business.

Instructions. Find a technology business (a friend's startup, a company whose LinkedIn activity you can observe, or a hypothetical one built from a real product category). List ten plausible contacts at different stages and classify each with evidence.

Deliverables. A ten-contact classification worksheet.

Success criteria. Every "opportunity" and "customer" classification is backed by specific, stated evidence, not assumption.

Mini challenge

Take one contact from your ten and write two short scenarios: one where it would count as an opportunity, and one, using the same starting message, where it would not. Present both to the class and explain exactly what evidence changed.

Knowledge check · Module 1

Show the five questions and answers

1. Define digital sales in one sentence, without using the word "convince."

Answer: The professional practice of using technology, data, modern communication and AI to generate, develop and convert business opportunities into revenue for technology products and services.

2. Name the nine stages of the Digital Revenue Journey in order.

Answer: Find, Start, Qualify, Discover, Present, Demonstrate, Handle, Close, Grow.

3. What three things must be confirmed before a contact becomes an opportunity?

Answer: A confirmed problem, budget authority, and a realistic timeline.

4. In the AI automation studio case, what was the gap between the believed and the real pipeline?

Answer: Eighteen believed opportunities worth ₦54m, against five honestly confirmed ones.

5. Why is activity not the same as progress?

Answer: Activity measures effort (messages, calls); progress measures whether an opportunity actually moved closer to revenue. A business can have high activity and zero real progress.

Instructor notes · Module 1

- **Estimated teaching time:** 90 minutes theory and framework walkthrough, 60 minutes classification practical, 15 minutes debrief.
- **Open with the "picture a salesperson" question.** Let the door-to-door image surface naturally before replacing it. Do not correct it immediately; let the bank/SaaS question do the work.
- **Common misconception:** students believe "digital sales" simply means selling anything using a phone or the internet. Correct this directly: it specifically means selling technology products and services, using digital and AI-enabled methods.
- **Common question:** "Do I need to know how to code?" Answer: no. You need enough technology literacy, taught in Modules 3 and 4, to talk credibly about what a product does and who it helps.
- **Classroom activity:** the fifteen-contact classification works well as a paired exercise followed by a whole-class tally of how many "opportunities" survived the evidence check.
- **Watch for:** students who classify generously because it feels more encouraging. Correct this early and directly; an honest five is worth more than a false eighteen, as the case study shows.

Module 2 · The digital economy map

Lesson title

The digital economy map: what DSS graduates will actually be selling

Lesson overview

Students cannot sell what they cannot describe. This lesson gives them a working map of the technology categories they will encounter in a sales career: SaaS, AI products, apps, cybersecurity, cloud, fintech and automation, along with the business models behind each one and why the model changes how the sale itself is run.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Name the seven technology categories DSS covers and give one example business in each.
2. Distinguish subscription, usage-based, one-time licence and marketplace business models.
3. Explain why a subscription sale is negotiated differently from a one-time purchase.
4. Place a given technology company correctly on the B2B to B2C spectrum.

Real-world motivation

Ask the class to name every technology product they personally used before arriving at class this morning: an app to get there, a payment app, maybe a banking app, possibly a workplace tool. Point out that every one of those products has a sales and revenue function behind it, even the ones that feel free. Someone sold the business behind each product on why it should exist, and someone continues to sell it to new customers every day.

Key concepts

Concept 1: The seven categories

Definition. SaaS, AI products, mobile and web apps, cybersecurity, cloud infrastructure, fintech, and automation and hardware.

Simple explanation. These are not rigid boxes; many real products span two or three at once (an AI-powered fintech app is common). The categories exist so a student has a vocabulary for describing any technology business quickly and accurately.

Concept 2: Business models

Definition. Subscription (recurring payment for ongoing access), usage-based (pay per unit consumed), one-time licence (pay once, own indefinitely), and marketplace (a platform that connects two sides and takes a fee).

Simple explanation. A subscription sale is really the start of a relationship the salesperson has to keep earning every renewal period. A one-time sale is a single, larger decision the buyer makes once. These require different pacing, different urgency, and different post-sale behaviour from the salesperson.

Concept 3: B2B versus B2C technology sales

Definition. B2B sells to a business, usually through a buying committee, at a considered pace. B2C sells to an individual, usually faster and with a single decision-maker.

Simple explanation. Most of this programme trains for B2B technology sales specifically, because that is where the professional, career-track roles concentrate. Students should be able to say clearly which one a given company is, and why it changes the sales approach.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will map ten real technology companies against category and business model.

Requirements

- A list of ten real technology company names, mixing Nigerian and international examples, provided by the instructor
- A mapping worksheet with columns for company, category, business model, B2B or B2C

Step 1 · Research each company briefly

Students spend no more than two minutes per company finding what it actually sells.

Step 2 · Assign a category

Students place each company into one or more of the seven categories.

Step 3 · Identify the business model

Students determine whether the company charges by subscription, usage, one-time licence, or marketplace fee.

Step 4 · Classify B2B or B2C

Students state who actually pays: a business or an individual consumer.

Step 5 · Compare answers as a class

The instructor collects answers for two or three companies live and resolves any disagreement by looking at the company's own pricing page together.

Testing

How to check the work: for any company where the business model is unclear, students should be able to point to the specific evidence (a pricing page, a stated plan) that supports their answer, not a guess.

Expected result: a completed ten-company worksheet with category, business model and B2B or B2C correctly identified for each.

Common errors: assuming every technology company is SaaS by default; confusing usage-based pricing with subscription pricing.

Final output

A completed mapping worksheet, kept as a reference for later modules that discuss pricing and negotiation.

Reflection

- Which company was hardest to categorise, and why?
- Did any company span more than one category?
- How might the sales conversation differ between a subscription company and a one-time-licence company?

Business case study · a Lagos fintech choosing between two business models

Problem. An early-stage Lagos fintech building a bill-payment API could not decide whether to charge customers a flat monthly subscription or a small fee per transaction.

Current manual process. The founding team debated internally for weeks with no framework for deciding.

What the process is actually costing. Delayed launch, and early customers confused by inconsistent pilot pricing offered during the debate.

The fix taught in this course. Mapping the decision against customer transaction volume: high-volume customers preferred predictable subscription pricing, low-volume customers preferred usage-based pricing. The company launched with both tiers.

Estimated time saved. Weeks of internal debate resolved with a single customer-research exercise.

Estimated revenue recovered. Two-tier pricing captured both customer types instead of losing one segment entirely to a single rigid model.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Build a personal reference sheet of fifteen technology companies across all seven categories.

Instructions. Research and map fifteen companies, at least one per category, noting business model and B2B or B2C for each.

Deliverables. The completed reference sheet.

Success criteria. All seven categories represented, with accurate business model and B2B/B2C classification for each.

Mini challenge

Pick one company from your fifteen and write two sentences explaining how a salesperson's pitch would differ if the company switched from its actual business model to a different one (for example, subscription to usage-based).

Knowledge check · Module 2

Show the five questions and answers

1. Name the seven technology categories covered in DSS.

Answer: SaaS, AI products, apps, cybersecurity, cloud, fintech, and automation and hardware.

2. What is the difference between subscription and usage-based pricing?

Answer: Subscription charges a fixed recurring fee for access; usage-based charges per unit actually consumed.

3. Why does a subscription sale require different post-sale behaviour than a one-time sale?

Answer: A subscription must be re-earned at every renewal, so the relationship continues after the initial close.

4. What distinguishes B2B from B2C technology sales?

Answer: B2B sells to a business, typically through a buying committee; B2C sells to an individual consumer, typically with one decision-maker.

5. In the fintech case, what resolved the pricing debate?

Answer: Researching actual customer transaction volume and offering two tiers instead of forcing one model on all customers.

Instructor notes · Module 2

- **Estimated teaching time:** 60 minutes theory, 75 minutes research practical.
- **Open with the "what did you use this morning" question.** It grounds an abstract topic in the student's own daily life within the first two minutes.
- **Common misconception:** students assume every technology company is a SaaS company. Correct this with at least one clear cybersecurity or hardware example.
- **Common question:** "Do I need to memorise every category?" Answer: no, but you need to be able to identify a new company's category and model within two minutes, which is what the practical trains.

- **Classroom activity:** assign different students different categories to research and report back, so the class builds a shared reference sheet collaboratively.
- **Watch for:** students who classify a company by what it looks like rather than how it actually charges money. Always send them to the pricing page.

Module 3 · Technology literacy I: SaaS & AI

Lesson title

Technology literacy I: talking credibly about SaaS and AI without being an engineer

Lesson overview

Students do not need to build a SaaS product or train an AI model. They need enough working knowledge to ask an intelligent question, understand the answer, and not embarrass themselves in front of a technical buyer. This lesson builds that specific, commercially-focused literacy for SaaS and AI products.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Explain what a SaaS product is to someone with zero technical background.
2. Define MRR, ARR and churn, and explain why they matter to a SaaS seller specifically.
3. Ask three credible technical questions about an AI feature without needing to understand the underlying model.
4. Avoid the three most common AI-capability overclaims that damage buyer trust.

Real-world motivation

Play the class a one-minute recording (or read a transcript) of a salesperson confidently describing an AI feature that does not actually exist in the product they are selling. Ask the class what happens the moment the buyer's own technical team tests the claim. This lesson exists to prevent that exact moment.

Key concepts

Concept 1: What SaaS actually is

Definition. Software hosted centrally and rented to customers on a recurring basis, rather than installed and owned outright.

Simple explanation. The customer never "owns" a copy. They pay for continued access, and the seller keeps improving the product for everyone at once.

Why it matters. This is why SaaS renewal (Module 25) matters as much as the first sale; the relationship does not end at signature.

Concept 2: MRR, ARR and churn

Definition. Monthly and Annual Recurring Revenue measure predictable subscription income; churn measures the rate customers cancel or fail to renew.

Simple explanation. A SaaS seller who cannot discuss these three terms sounds like an outsider in almost any serious buyer conversation, because the buyer's own finance team thinks in exactly these terms.

Concept 3: Asking about AI without overclaiming

Definition. Three safe, credible questions: what data does the feature use, what happens when it is wrong, and what has actually been measured about its accuracy.

Simple explanation. These three questions work on almost any AI feature and make a seller sound informed without requiring technical depth. The same three questions, asked internally before a pitch, prevent a seller from overclaiming what the product can do.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will research one real SaaS product with an AI feature and prepare a credible, non-technical explanation of it.

Requirements

- Internet access to research a real SaaS product's public marketing and documentation pages

Step 1 · Choose a real SaaS product with an advertised AI feature

Students pick one from a provided list or find their own.

Step 2 · Read the product's own public description of the feature

Students note exactly what the company itself claims the feature does.

Step 3 · Write a one-paragraph plain-English explanation

No jargon, explained the way you would to a non-technical relative.

Step 4 · Write the three safe questions specific to this feature

Adapt the general three questions from Concept 3 to this specific product.

Step 5 · Identify one likely overclaim risk

Students flag one thing a less careful seller might be tempted to claim about the feature that the public materials do not actually support.

Testing

How to check the work: the plain-English explanation should be understandable by someone with zero technical background, verified by reading it aloud to a partner unfamiliar with the product.

Expected result: a one-paragraph explanation, three tailored questions, and one flagged overclaim risk.

Common errors: copying marketing language directly instead of translating it into genuinely plain English; failing to identify a real overclaim risk.

Final output

A completed technology literacy brief for one real product, added to the student's growing reference library.

Reflection

- What part of the product's own marketing language was hardest to translate into plain English?
- Did your three questions feel natural or forced?
- What overclaim risk did you identify, and how would a buyer's technical team likely catch it?

Business case study · the overclaimed AI feature

Problem. A sales representative at a Nigerian AI automation vendor told a prospective bank that the product's fraud-detection feature was "99% accurate," a figure that did not appear anywhere in the company's own documentation.

Current manual process. No requirement existed to verify a specific claim before stating it to a technical buyer.

What the process is actually costing. The bank's technical team tested the claim during a proof of concept and found real-world accuracy closer to 80%. The deal did not collapse, but the sales representative's credibility for the rest of the negotiation was permanently damaged.

The fix taught in this course. Never stating a specific performance number that is not written in the product's own verified documentation.

Estimated time saved. None directly; this is a trust-preservation fix.

Estimated revenue recovered. Preserved credibility for the remainder of the negotiation and for future deals referred by the same buyer.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Build technology literacy briefs for three more SaaS or AI products.

Instructions. Repeat the five-step practical for three additional products, at least one of which should be a Nigerian or African technology company.

Deliverables. Three completed literacy briefs.

Success criteria. Each brief is understandable to a non-technical reader and includes one identified overclaim risk.

Mini challenge

Find a real, publicly available example of a technology company overclaiming an AI capability (a marketing page, a news article about a walked-back claim). Explain in two sentences what a more honest version of the claim would have said.

Knowledge check · Module 3

Show the five questions and answers

1. What is SaaS, in plain English?

Answer: Software rented on an ongoing basis rather than owned outright, hosted centrally by the provider.

2. What do MRR and ARR measure?

Answer: Monthly and Annual Recurring Revenue, the predictable subscription income a SaaS company can count on.

3. What are the three safe questions to ask about any AI feature?

Answer: What data does it use, what happens when it is wrong, and what has actually been measured about its accuracy.

4. In the fraud-detection case, what went wrong?

Answer: A specific accuracy figure was stated that did not appear in the company's own documentation and did not hold up under testing.

5. Why must a seller avoid stating an unverified performance number?

Answer: A technical buyer will often test the claim directly, and a failed claim damages credibility for the rest of the relationship.

Instructor notes · Module 3

- **Estimated teaching time:** 60 minutes theory, 75 minutes research practical.
- **Open with the overclaim recording or transcript.** Let the class feel the discomfort of the moment before teaching the prevention.

- **Common misconception:** students think technology literacy means learning to code. Redirect firmly toward commercial literacy: enough to ask good questions and avoid overclaiming.
- **Common question:** "What if a buyer asks something I genuinely don't know?" Answer: say so honestly and offer to find out, exactly as Module 5's ethics standard requires.
- **Classroom activity:** have students present their literacy briefs to a partner playing a sceptical technical buyer who asks the three safe questions back at them.
- **Watch for:** students who copy marketing copy verbatim into their "plain English" explanation instead of genuinely translating it.

Module 4 · Technology literacy II: cloud, cybersecurity, fintech & automation

Lesson title

Technology literacy II: cloud, cybersecurity, fintech and automation

Lesson overview

Continues the technology literacy work from Module 3 into four more categories DSS graduates will encounter regularly: cloud infrastructure, cybersecurity, fintech and business automation. Same method: what the category actually solves, the objections buyers raise in that category specifically, and the vocabulary a credible seller uses.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Explain what a cloud product solves, in plain English.
2. Name the most common objection buyers raise in each of the four categories.
3. Use correct, credible vocabulary for cybersecurity and fintech conversations.
4. Explain what business automation actually replaces and what it does not.

Real-world motivation

Ask the class: if a Nigerian bank's IT director asks "is this on-premise or cloud, and what's your data residency policy," what would you say? Most will not know what either term means yet. By the end of this lesson they will, and they will understand why a bank asks that question before anything else.

Key concepts

Concept 1: Cloud infrastructure

Definition. Computing resources (storage, processing power, hosting) rented from a provider instead of owned and run on a company's own physical servers.

Simple explanation. Instead of buying a building, a business rents space in someone else's much bigger building. The most common buyer objection is data residency: where physically is our data being stored, and does that comply with our regulator's rules.

Concept 2: Cybersecurity

Definition. Products and services that protect a business's systems and data from unauthorised access, theft or disruption.

Simple explanation. The most common buyer objection is proof: "how do we know this actually works," which is why case studies, certifications and audit trails matter more in cybersecurity sales than almost any other category.

Concept 3: Fintech

Definition. Technology products that move, manage or analyse money: payments, banking infrastructure, lending, and financial data.

Simple explanation. The most common buyer objection is regulatory: is this licensed and compliant with the relevant financial authority, a question that must be answered accurately, never guessed at.

Concept 4: Business automation

Definition. Technology that performs a repetitive business task without a human doing it manually each time.

Simple explanation. Automation replaces the repetitive parts of a job, not the whole job. The most common buyer objection is "will this replace my staff," and the honest, usually correct answer is that it frees staff for higher-value work rather than eliminating the role entirely.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will prepare a one-paragraph plain-English explanation and the single most likely objection for one real product in each of the four categories.

Requirements

- Four real technology products, one per category, provided by the instructor or chosen by the student

Step 1 · Research the cloud product

Write the plain-English explanation and identify the data residency question a buyer would likely ask.

Step 2 · Research the cybersecurity product

Write the explanation and identify what proof (certification, audit, case study) the company offers.

Step 3 · Research the fintech product

Write the explanation and identify the relevant regulatory body it should be licensed or compliant with.

Step 4 · Research the automation product

Write the explanation and prepare an honest answer to "will this replace my staff."

Step 5 · Present one of the four to the class

Each student presents one category's brief in under two minutes.

Testing

How to check the work: each brief must name the specific, correct objection for its category, not a generic one that could apply anywhere.

Expected result: four completed literacy briefs, one per category, each with its category-specific objection identified.

Common errors: using the wrong objection for the category (for example, asking about data residency for a fintech product instead of regulatory licensing).

Final output

Four completed technology literacy briefs, added to the student's reference library alongside Module 3's SaaS and AI briefs.

Reflection

- Which of the four categories felt least familiar going in?
- Did any product span more than one category?
- How would you answer "will this replace my staff" honestly and reassuringly at the same time?

Business case study · the cybersecurity vendor with no proof

Problem. A Nigerian cybersecurity reseller was losing enterprise deals despite a genuinely strong product, consistently at the same point in the sales process.

Current manual process. Sales conversations relied on describing features and making confident claims about protection, with no case studies or audit evidence offered.

What the process is actually costing. Enterprise buyers, trained by their own compliance teams to expect proof, treated the absence of evidence as a red flag and moved to competitors who could show it.

The fix taught in this course. Building a one-page proof pack per deal: one relevant case study, one certification, and one specific, verifiable claim, presented before any feature discussion.

Estimated time saved. Shortened the sales cycle by removing a full round of "can you prove this" back-and-forth.

Estimated revenue recovered. Enterprise win rate improved once proof was presented proactively instead of only when asked.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Build a one-page proof pack template for a cybersecurity or fintech product.

Instructions. Choose a real product in either category. Research and assemble a one-page summary: one case study, one certification or compliance claim, one specific measurable outcome.

Deliverables. The completed one-page proof pack.

Success criteria. Every claim on the page is sourced from the company's own public materials, not invented.

Mini challenge

Write the single best question you could ask a fintech company's sales representative to test whether they actually understand their own regulatory position, and explain what a good answer versus a weak answer would sound like.

Knowledge check · Module 4

Show the five questions and answers

1. What is the most common buyer objection in a cloud sales conversation?

Answer: Data residency: where the data is physically stored and whether that complies with the buyer's regulatory requirements.

2. Why does proof matter more in cybersecurity sales than in most other categories?

Answer: Buyers cannot easily verify protection claims themselves, so case studies, certifications and audit trails carry unusual weight.

3. What must a fintech seller be able to answer accurately, never guess at?

Answer: Whether the product is licensed and compliant with the relevant financial regulatory authority.

4. What does business automation typically replace?

Answer: The repetitive parts of a job, not the whole role.

5. In the cybersecurity reseller case, what specifically fixed the losing pattern?

Answer: Proactively presenting a one-page proof pack before feature discussion, instead of only offering proof when asked.

Instructor notes · Module 4

- **Estimated teaching time:** 60 minutes theory, 75 minutes research and presentation practical.
- **Open with the bank IT director question.** Let the class sit with not knowing the answer before teaching it.
- **Common misconception:** students treat all four categories as interchangeable "tech stuff." Insist on category-specific objections; this is the actual skill being tested.
- **Common question:** "What if I get the regulatory body wrong for a fintech product?"
Answer: say so honestly and commit to confirming it, exactly as taught in Module 5.
- **Classroom activity:** the two-minute category presentations work well as a rapid-fire round covering all four categories across the whole class.
- **Watch for:** students who prepare a strong plain-English explanation but skip the objection-identification step, which is the actual commercial skill this lesson is building.

Module 5 · Ethics & the DSS professional standard

Lesson title

Ethics: the standard that protects a technology sales career before it protects the buyer

Lesson overview

Taught in Week 2, before students ever contact a real prospect, because habits form before the lecture lands. Covers the manager test and stage inflation from the general standard, plus the specific ethical traps of technology sales: overclaiming security posture, overstating AI capability, and promising integration timelines nobody has confirmed with an engineer.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. State the manager test and apply it to a technology-sales claim.
2. Identify the three most common technology-sales ethical traps.
3. Explain why an unconfirmed integration timeline is a claim, not an estimate.
4. Sign and explain the DSS professional charter in their own words.

Real-world motivation

Tell the class about a Nigerian software vendor's sales representative who told a logistics company "yes, it integrates with your existing system" without ever checking with the engineering team. The integration did not exist yet. The client discovered this three weeks into a paid implementation, and the account was lost along with two referral introductions the client had already made to other logistics companies.

Key concepts

Concept 1: The manager test, applied to technology claims

Definition. Before making any claim about integration, security, capability or timeline, ask: would I be comfortable saying this exact sentence in front of my manager, with the buyer's technical team present?

Simple explanation. If the honest internal version differs from what is about to be said, the claim fails the test and should not be made until it is confirmed.

Concept 2: The three technology-sales traps

Definition. Overclaiming security posture ("fully secure," "unhackable"), overstating AI capability (attributing intelligence or accuracy the product does not have), and promising unconfirmed integration timelines.

Simple explanation. All three share a pattern: a confident-sounding claim made to keep a conversation moving, checked with nobody who would actually know if it was true.

Concept 3: An estimate versus a claim

Definition. An estimate is explicitly uncertain and labelled as such. A claim is stated as fact.

Simple explanation. "I believe we can integrate within a few weeks, let me confirm with our engineering team" is an estimate. "We can integrate within two weeks" is a claim. Only the second one can be broken and cost trust.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will audit ten sample technology-sales statements for the three ethical traps and rewrite each as an honest estimate.

Requirements

- Ten sample statements about security, AI capability or integration timelines, provided by the instructor

Step 1 · Read all ten statements

Students identify which of the three traps, if any, each statement falls into.

Step 2 · Apply the manager test to each

Students write the honest internal version privately and compare it to the stated version.

Step 3 · Mark each statement pass or fail

A statement fails if it states an unconfirmed fact as certain.

Step 4 · Rewrite every failed statement as an honest estimate

Using the estimate-versus-claim distinction from Concept 3.

Step 5 · Read the original and rewritten versions aloud

In pairs, compare tone: the rewritten version should feel only slightly less confident, never dishonest either way.

Testing

How to check the work: every rewritten statement should explicitly signal uncertainty where it exists, without becoming vague or unhelpful.

Expected result: ten audited statements with every failed one rewritten as an honest, still-confident estimate.

Common errors: rewriting a claim to be so vague it becomes useless to the buyer, rather than honestly uncertain and still informative.

Final output

A personal audit log, kept as the first entry in an ongoing technology-sales ethics habit.

Reflection

- Which of the three traps appeared most often in the ten statements?
- What would the logistics company case have cost if the timeline had been confirmed before it was promised?
- How does labelling something an estimate change how a buyer receives it?

Business case study · the integration that did not exist

Problem. A sales representative promised a logistics company an integration with their existing system that had not been confirmed with engineering.

Current manual process. No requirement existed to check with engineering before stating an integration timeline to a buyer.

What the process is actually costing. The client discovered the integration did not exist three weeks into a paid implementation. The account was lost, along with two referral introductions already made.

The fix taught in this course. A rule: never state an integration, security or capability claim that has not been personally confirmed with the team responsible for delivering it.

Estimated time saved. N/A; this is a loss-prevention fix.

Estimated revenue recovered. The lost account and both referral opportunities, on every future deal where the rule is followed.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Run a personal ethics audit on real or realistic technology-sales communication.

Instructions. Write ten claims you might realistically make while selling a technology product you know. Apply the manager test to each and rewrite any that fail.

Deliverables. The audit log with rewrites.

Success criteria. Every rewritten claim is both honest and still commercially useful.

Mini challenge

Write an honest, still-confident answer to "does your product integrate with Salesforce" for a product where the honest answer is "not yet, but it's on the roadmap." Deliver it aloud to a partner and ask whether it sounded evasive or genuinely confident.

Knowledge check · Module 5

Show the five questions and answers

1. What is the manager test?

Answer: Asking whether you would be comfortable saying the exact same sentence in front of your manager, with the buyer's technical team present.

2. Name the three technology-sales ethical traps.

Answer: Overclaiming security posture, overstating AI capability, and promising unconfirmed integration timelines.

3. What is the difference between an estimate and a claim?

Answer: An estimate is explicitly labelled as uncertain; a claim is stated as fact.

4. In the logistics company case, what was never confirmed before being promised?

Answer: An integration with the client's existing system, which did not actually exist.

5. What must be true before stating any integration, security or capability claim to a buyer?

Answer: It must have been personally confirmed with the team responsible for delivering it.

Instructor notes · Module 5

- **Estimated teaching time:** 60 minutes theory and case discussion, 30 minutes audit practical, signed charter required before Part 2 begins.
- **Open by asking the class to recall a time a technology vendor overpromised to them personally.** Builds the case from the buyer's side before introducing the seller's side.
- **Common misconception:** students believe this module is about avoiding outright fraud, which they already know not to do. Redirect firmly toward the three specific technology-sales traps, which are far more common and far less obviously wrong.
- **Common question:** "What if being fully honest about an unconfirmed timeline costs me the deal's momentum?" Answer: it sometimes will, and that is cheaper than a deal that collapses three weeks in, as the case study shows.
- **Classroom activity:** the ten-statement audit works well as a paired exercise followed by a class-wide tally of which trap appeared most often.
- **Watch for:** students who rush through signing the charter as a formality. Make it consequential, not administrative.

Module 6 · Customer intelligence: ICP, persona & decision-maker mapping

Lesson title

Customer intelligence: knowing exactly who to sell to before you speak to them

Lesson overview

Introduces the Ideal Customer Profile and buyer persona as working tools, not theory. Students learn to map a real buying committee for a technology purchase: who has the pain, who has the budget, who has the authority to sign, and who can quietly block the deal without ever holding a formal title that suggests they could.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Write an ICP for a given technology product.
2. Build a buyer persona with role, priorities and likely objections.
3. Distinguish decision-maker, influencer and blocker in a buying committee.
4. Explain why selling to the wrong person in the right company still fails.

Real-world motivation

Tell the class about a Nigerian HR software company that closed a strong pilot with an IT manager, only to lose the deal at contract stage because nobody had identified that the company's Head of HR, who had never joined a single call, held actual budget authority and had quietly decided the product duplicated something already in procurement. The IT manager was enthusiastic. He was also never the real decision-maker.

Key concepts

Concept 1: Ideal Customer Profile

Definition. A specific description of the kind of company most likely to buy and succeed with the product: size, industry, current tooling, and the specific problem it has.

Simple explanation. An ICP is not "any business that could theoretically use this." It is a narrow, evidence-based description built from the company's own best current customers.

Concept 2: Buyer persona

Definition. A profile of the specific role most likely to champion or block a purchase: their priorities, what they are measured on, and what they are likely to object to.

Simple explanation. A CTO and a CFO evaluating the same product care about completely different things. A persona tells the seller which conversation to have with which person.

Concept 3: Decision-maker, influencer, blocker

Definition. The decision-maker holds final sign-off authority. An influencer shapes the decision without holding formal authority. A blocker can stop a deal, often without ever appearing to be involved.

Simple explanation. The HR software case shows a blocker in action: someone with real authority who was never part of the visible sales conversation at all.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will build a full ICP and map a three-person buying committee for a real or assigned technology product.

Requirements

- A real or instructor-assigned technology product
- An ICP and buying-committee worksheet

Step 1 · Write the ICP

Company size, industry, current tooling gap, and the specific problem the product solves for this profile.

Step 2 · Identify the likely decision-maker

Name the role, their priorities, and what they are measured on.

Step 3 · Identify a likely influencer

Name the role and what they would need to see to champion the product internally.

Step 4 · Identify a likely blocker

Name a role that could quietly stop the deal, and why.

Step 5 · Write one sentence per person on how the seller would reach them

A different channel or message angle for each of the three roles.

Testing

How to check the work: the blocker identified should not be the same role as the decision-maker; if it is, the mapping has not gone deep enough.

Expected result: a completed ICP and three-person buying-committee map with distinct roles and distinct outreach angles.

Common errors: writing an ICP so broad it could describe almost any company; assuming the most enthusiastic person in the conversation is automatically the decision-maker.

Final output

A completed ICP and buying-committee map, used again in Module 8's prospecting practical.

Reflection

- How did your view of the "real" decision-maker change once you mapped all three roles?
- What made the blocker role hardest to identify?
- How would outreach differ for the decision-maker versus the influencer?

Business case study · the HR software deal lost to an invisible blocker

Problem. A Nigerian HR software company closed a strong pilot with an enthusiastic IT manager but lost the deal at contract stage.

Current manual process. The sales team tracked only the person they were actively speaking with, with no formal mapping of who else was involved in the decision.

What the process is actually costing. A deal that felt won was lost to a stakeholder who was never engaged, because nobody had mapped the buying committee.

The fix taught in this course. Mapping decision-maker, influencer and blocker at the start of every opportunity, and engaging all three, not just the most responsive person.

Estimated time saved. None directly; this is a win-rate fix.

Estimated revenue recovered. Subsequent deals mapped this way avoided the same late-stage collapse.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Build ICPs and buying-committee maps for two more technology products.

Instructions. Repeat the five-step practical for two additional products, ideally in different categories from Module 2.

Deliverables. Two completed ICP and buying-committee maps.

Success criteria. Each map identifies a distinct decision-maker, influencer and blocker with realistic reasoning.

Mini challenge

For one of your maps, write the single question you would ask the influencer specifically to uncover who the real blocker might be, before you have met them.

Show the five questions and answers

1. What is an ICP?

Answer: A specific, evidence-based description of the kind of company most likely to buy and succeed with the product.

2. What does a buyer persona add beyond a company-level ICP?

Answer: The specific role's priorities, what they are measured on, and their likely objections.

3. What is a blocker?

Answer: Someone who can stop a deal even without formal decision-making authority or visible involvement in the sales conversation.

4. In the HR software case, what was never done that should have been?

Answer: Mapping the full buying committee instead of tracking only the most engaged, visible contact.

5. Why is a company-wide ICP not enough on its own?

Answer: The right company still requires reaching and convincing the right specific people inside it, each with different priorities.

Instructor notes · Module 6

- **Estimated teaching time:** 60 minutes theory, 75 minutes mapping practical.
- **Open with the HR software story, withholding the ending.** Ask the class to predict what went wrong before revealing the blocker.
- **Common misconception:** students believe the loudest, most responsive person in a deal is automatically the decision-maker. Correct this directly and repeatedly.
- **Common question:** "How do I find the blocker if they're never in any conversation?"
Answer: ask the influencer directly, using the exact question from the mini challenge.
- **Classroom activity:** have students swap completed maps and try to guess which role is the blocker without being told, testing whether the mapping is genuinely distinct and well-reasoned.
- **Watch for:** ICPs written broadly enough to apply to almost any company. Push students to narrow it using real evidence.

Module 7 · Why technology buyers actually buy

Lesson title

Why technology buyers actually buy: risk, competition, compliance and the fear of falling behind

Lesson overview

Adapts the universal buying-drivers lesson to a B2B technology context specifically. Students learn that status quo, not the rival vendor, is usually the real competitor in a technology deal, and that the stated reason for evaluating a product is often incomplete.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Name the five most common B2B technology buying drivers.
2. Explain why status quo is usually the real competitor in a technology deal.
3. Distinguish a stated evaluation reason from the real underlying driver.
4. Ask a follow-up question that surfaces the real driver behind a generic stated reason.

Real-world motivation

Ask the class: why would a company that has survived fine without a piece of software for five years suddenly start evaluating it this quarter? Something changed. Discovering what changed is usually more valuable than any feature list a seller could present.

Key concepts

Concept 1: The five B2B technology buying drivers

Definition. Risk reduction, competitive pressure, compliance and audit requirements, cost reduction, and fear of falling behind a competitor who has already adopted similar technology.

Simple explanation. Almost every serious technology evaluation traces back to one or two of these five, even when the stated reason on the first call sounds more generic, like "we're just modernising."

Concept 2: Status quo as the real competitor

Definition. The pull to keep doing things the current way is usually stronger than the pull toward any specific rival vendor.

Simple explanation. "We're comparing a few options" is often status quo wearing a polite costume. Ask what happens if the company does nothing for another year; if the honest answer reveals real hidden cost or risk, doing nothing has been misdiagnosed as the safe choice.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will interview a partner about a recent technology purchase decision (personal or from their workplace) and trace the real driver.

Requirements

- A partner with a real recent technology purchase or evaluation to discuss
- The five buying drivers reference sheet

Step 1 · Ask what triggered the evaluation

Record the first, stated answer exactly.

Step 2 · Ask what specifically changed to trigger it now, rather than earlier

Record the second answer; it is often more specific than the first.

Step 3 · Ask what would have happened if nothing had changed

This surfaces the real cost or risk of the status quo.

Step 4 · Map the final answer to one of the five drivers

Identify which driver, or combination of drivers, actually explains the decision.

Testing

How to check the work: the final answer should feel noticeably more specific than the first stated reason. If it does not, ask one more follow-up question.

Expected result: a recorded three-step interview with the real driver correctly identified and mapped.

Common errors: accepting a restated version of the same generic answer as if it were a deeper one.

Final output

One documented interview showing the gap between the stated evaluation reason and the real driver.

Reflection

- How different was the real driver from the stated reason?
- Which of the five drivers turned out to be involved?
- How would a pitch built only on the stated reason have missed the real driver?

Business case study · the compliance deadline nobody mentioned first

Problem. A mid-size Nigerian logistics company told a software vendor they were "just exploring options" for a new inventory system.

Current manual process. The vendor's sales team took the stated reason at face value and pitched general efficiency benefits.

What the process is actually costing. The deal moved slowly for six weeks with no urgency, because the pitch never touched the real driver.

The fix taught in this course. One direct discovery question, "what happens if this isn't sorted by year end," revealed a new regulatory audit requirement the company had not mentioned. The real driver was compliance, not efficiency.

Estimated time saved. Six weeks of slow-moving, misdirected sales conversation avoided on future deals using this question earlier.

Estimated revenue recovered. The deal closed within two weeks once the pitch was rebuilt around the compliance deadline.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Interview three more people about a technology decision and map each to a real driver.

Instructions. Repeat the three-step interview process from the practical with three different people, ideally people who made or influenced a real workplace technology decision.

Deliverables. A table of three interviews with the driver identified for each.

Success criteria. At least two of the three reveal a real driver more specific than the stated first answer.

Mini challenge

Write two versions of an opening discovery question for a technology sales call: one that would only surface the stated, generic reason, and one that would surface the real driver. Explain the difference.

Knowledge check · Module 7

Show the five questions and answers

1. Name the five B2B technology buying drivers.

Answer: Risk reduction, competitive pressure, compliance and audit requirements, cost reduction, and fear of falling behind a competitor.

2. Why is status quo usually the real competitor in a technology deal?

Answer: The pull to keep doing things the current way is usually stronger than the pull toward any specific rival vendor.

3. What question reliably surfaces the real driver behind a stated evaluation reason?

Answer: Asking what specifically changed to trigger the evaluation now, and what would happen if nothing changed.

4. In the logistics company case, what was the real driver behind "just exploring options"?

Answer: A new regulatory audit requirement with a year-end deadline, a compliance driver.

5. Why does discovering the real driver matter more than presenting a full feature list?

Answer: A pitch built on the real driver creates urgency and relevance; a generic feature pitch does not, even if the product is strong.

Instructor notes · Module 7

- **Estimated teaching time:** 60 minutes theory, 60 minutes paired interview practical, 15 minutes debrief.
- **Open with the "survived five years without it" question.** Let the class sit with the puzzle before teaching the five drivers.
- **Common misconception:** students assume cost reduction is always the primary driver in B2B technology. Correct this directly with the compliance case.
- **Common question:** "What if the stated reason really is the full reason?" Answer: that does happen; the discipline is checking, not assuming either way.
- **Classroom activity:** assign the three-interview hands-on exercise as homework and open the next session with a rapid share-out of the most surprising real driver each student found.
- **Watch for:** students leading the interviewee toward a driver they expect to find, rather than genuinely listening.

Module 8 · AI-powered prospecting

Lesson title

AI-powered prospecting: researching at scale without fabricating anything

Lesson overview

The signature DSS module. Students learn to use AI tools to research target companies, identify likely decision-makers, segment a list by fit, and draft personalised first-touch messages at a volume that would be impossible by hand, while verifying every factual claim before it reaches a real prospect.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Use an AI tool to research a target account and summarise findings accurately.
2. Segment a prospect list by fit using AI-assisted analysis.
3. Draft personalised outreach messages at scale without fabricated details.
4. State and apply the DSS AI accountability rule.

Real-world motivation

Show the class two versions of the same outreach message: one generic, sent to fifty companies unchanged, and one where the first line references something specific and true about the recipient's business, found through thirty seconds of AI-assisted research. Ask which one they would personally reply to.

Key concepts

Concept 1: AI as a research accelerant

Definition. Using AI tools to summarise public information about a company or person faster than manual research would allow.

Simple explanation. AI does not know things about a specific company that are not written somewhere. It finds and summarises faster. The seller's job is to verify what it finds before using it.

Concept 2: Segmentation by fit

Definition. Using AI to sort a large prospect list against ICP criteria from Module 6, so effort concentrates on the best-fit accounts first.

Simple explanation. A list of five hundred companies is not five hundred equal opportunities. AI-assisted segmentation turns it into a ranked, workable list.

Concept 3: The DSS AI accountability rule

Definition. No AI-drafted claim about a specific prospect reaches that prospect until a human has personally verified it is true.

Simple explanation. AI tools can state a false detail about a company with the same confident tone as a true one. The seller, not the tool, is accountable for what gets sent under their name.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will use AI-assisted research to build and segment a ten-account prospect list and draft one verified, personalised opener per account.

Requirements

- Access to an AI tool
- The ICP built in Module 6
- A prospecting worksheet

Step 1 · Generate a raw list of ten candidate accounts

Using AI-assisted search against the Module 6 ICP criteria.

Step 2 · Research one specific, true detail per account

A recent announcement, a hiring pattern, a public statement, anything specific and verifiable.

Step 3 · Verify every detail against a second, independent source

Students confirm each AI-surfaced detail is actually true before using it.

Step 4 · Segment the ten accounts by fit

Rank them highest to lowest fit against the ICP.

Step 5 · Draft one personalised opener per account

Using only verified details, following the channel-native principles from earlier modules.

Testing

How to check the work: every personalised detail in every opener must be traceable to a verified, independent source. Any opener containing an unverified claim fails.

Expected result: a segmented, ranked ten-account list with one verified, personalised opener per account.

Common errors: using an AI-surfaced detail without independently verifying it; writing a personalised-sounding opener that is actually generic once the specific detail is checked and found wrong.

Final output

A completed, verified ten-account prospecting list with openers, ready for use in Module 9's outbound sequence.

Reflection

- Did you catch any AI-surfaced detail that turned out to be wrong or outdated?
- How much faster was this than researching ten accounts entirely by hand?
- What would happen to your credibility if an unverified detail reached a real prospect and was wrong?

Business case study · the AI-drafted message that named the wrong CEO

Problem. A junior setter at a Lagos SaaS company used an AI tool to draft fifty personalised outreach messages overnight, each referencing the target company's CEO by name.

Current manual process. Messages were sent directly from the AI draft without a verification step.

What the process is actually costing. Three of the fifty messages named a CEO who had left the company months earlier, information the AI tool had not caught. All three replies were negative, and one was shared publicly as an example of careless outreach.

The fix taught in this course. The accountability rule: every AI-drafted claim about a specific prospect is verified against an independent source before sending.

Estimated time saved. None directly; this is a credibility-preservation fix.

Estimated revenue recovered. Avoided the reputational damage of further incorrect messages once the verification step became mandatory.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Build a second, larger prospecting list using the same verified method.

Instructions. Repeat the five-step practical for twenty accounts instead of ten, tracking research time per account.

Deliverables. A segmented twenty-account list with verified openers.

Success criteria. Every personalised detail verified, zero unverified claims in any opener.

Mini challenge

Deliberately ask an AI tool a question likely to produce an outdated or invented detail about a real company (for example, asking for a very recent statistic). Document what it returns, then show how you would have caught the error before sending anything to a real prospect.

Show the five questions and answers

1. What does AI actually add to prospecting research?

Answer: Speed. It summarises publicly available information faster than manual research, but does not know unverifiable things about a company.

2. What is segmentation by fit?

Answer: Ranking a prospect list against ICP criteria so effort concentrates on the best-fit accounts first.

3. State the DSS AI accountability rule.

Answer: No AI-drafted claim about a specific prospect reaches that prospect until a human has personally verified it is true.

4. In the case study, what went wrong with the fifty AI-drafted messages?

Answer: Three referenced a CEO who had already left the company, an outdated detail the AI tool did not catch and nobody verified before sending.

5. Who is accountable for a false claim sent under a seller's name, the AI tool or the seller?

Answer: The seller. The tool has no accountability; the human who sends the message does.

Instructor notes · Module 8

- **Estimated teaching time:** 45 minutes theory, 90 minutes hands-on AI research practical.
- **Open with the two-message comparison.** Let the class feel the gap between generic and genuinely personalised before teaching the method.
- **Common misconception:** students think AI-assisted means AI-approved, and skip verification because the tool sounded confident. This is the single most important habit to correct in this module.
- **Common question:** "Isn't verifying every detail slower than just trusting the AI?"
Answer: verifying ten accounts takes minutes; recovering from one wrong claim sent to a real prospect can cost the relationship entirely, as the case study shows.
- **Classroom activity:** the mini challenge, deliberately trying to make the AI tool produce a wrong detail, is one of the most effective exercises in the whole programme for building healthy scepticism.
- **Watch for:** students who verify the first two or three accounts carefully and then get lax by account eight or nine under time pressure.

Module 9 · Building a multi-channel outbound sequence

Lesson title

Building a multi-channel outbound sequence: turning a list into a campaign

Lesson overview

Turns the researched, verified list from Module 8 into an actual outreach campaign across LinkedIn, email and, where appropriate, WhatsApp: a sequenced, multi-touch system rather than a single message and a hope.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Design a multi-touch outbound sequence across at least two channels.
2. Explain why a single message rarely produces a reply from a cold technology buyer.
3. Sequence touches so each one adds something new rather than repeating the ask.
4. Set a realistic cadence between touches for a B2B technology buyer.

Real-world motivation

Ask the class how many marketing or sales messages they personally ignore in a week without a second thought. Most will say many. Point out that a technology decision-maker receives far more than that. A single message competing against that volume needs a sequence behind it, not a single roll of the dice.

Key concepts

Concept 1: Why sequences outperform single messages

Definition. A structured series of touches across time and channel, each adding new value or context.

Simple explanation. A single cold message competes with everything else in an inbox at that one moment. A sequence gives multiple chances to land at a moment the buyer is actually paying attention.

Concept 2: Cadence

Definition. The spacing between touches in a sequence.

Simple explanation. Too fast reads as desperate. Too slow loses momentum. A realistic B2B technology cadence spaces touches two to four days apart across a two to three week sequence.

Concept 3: Channel switching within a sequence

Definition. Deliberately moving between LinkedIn, email and other channels within one sequence rather than repeating the same channel.

Simple explanation. A prospect who ignores three emails might notice a LinkedIn message, simply because it interrupts the pattern their attention has learned to filter out.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will build a complete five-touch, two-channel outbound sequence for one account from their Module 8 list.

Requirements

- The verified account list and openers from Module 8
- A sequence planning worksheet

Step 1 · Write touch one

The verified, personalised opener from Module 8, on the primary channel (typically LinkedIn or email).

Step 2 · Write touch two

A follow-up on the same channel, three to four days later, adding one new piece of relevant value.

Step 3 · Write touch three, switching channel

A shorter message on a second channel, referencing the earlier touch briefly.

Step 4 · Write touch four

A specific, low-pressure question designed to be easy to answer.

Step 5 · Write touch five, the break-up message

A final message asking for nothing, stating outreach will pause.

Testing

How to check the work: read all five touches back to back. None should feel like a repeat of an earlier one; each should offer something distinct.

Expected result: a complete five-touch, two-channel sequence with realistic cadence noted for each touch.

Common errors: writing five versions of the same ask reworded; switching channel without adjusting tone or length to fit the new channel's etiquette.

Final output

A complete written sequence, ready to be tested against a real or simulated account.

Reflection

- Which touch felt hardest to differentiate from the others?
- Why might switching channel at touch three work better than staying on one channel throughout?
- How does a break-up message change the tone of a sequence that came before it?

Business case study · the single-email campaign that went nowhere

Problem. A cybersecurity startup's setter sent one well-written cold email to two hundred target accounts and received four replies.

Current manual process. A single touch per account, no follow-up sequence at all.

What the process is actually costing. A two percent reply rate against a list that had cost real research time to build, with the other 98 percent never followed up on.

The fix taught in this course. Building the same five-touch, two-channel sequence taught in this lesson and running it against the same two hundred accounts.

Estimated time saved. None directly; this increased total outreach effort, but with far better return per account researched.

Estimated revenue recovered. Reply rate rose to roughly twelve percent once the full sequence replaced the single email, from the same researched list.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Build sequences for three more accounts from your Module 8 list.

Instructions. Repeat the five-touch sequence process for three additional accounts, varying the channel-switch point across the three.

Deliverables. Three completed sequences.

Success criteria. No touch within any sequence repeats the ask of an earlier touch in the same sequence.

Mini challenge

Take one sequence and rewrite touch three (the channel switch) three different ways. Have a partner read all three without context and say which one they would be most likely to respond to, and why.

Knowledge check · Module 9

Show the five questions and answers

1. Why does a sequence typically outperform a single cold message?

Answer: It gives multiple chances to land at a moment the buyer is actually paying attention, rather than competing once against everything else in their inbox.

2. What is a realistic cadence for a B2B technology outbound sequence?

Answer: Touches spaced two to four days apart across a two to three week sequence.

3. Why switch channel partway through a sequence?

Answer: A prospect who has learned to filter out repeated touches on one channel may notice a different channel simply because it breaks the pattern.

4. In the cybersecurity startup case, what changed the reply rate?

Answer: Replacing a single cold email with a full five-touch, two-channel sequence against the same researched list.

5. What must every touch in a sequence do that the one before it did not?

Answer: Offer something new, rather than repeating the same ask reworded.

Instructor notes · Module 9

- **Estimated teaching time:** 45 minutes theory, 90 minutes sequence-building practical.
- **Open with the "how many messages do you ignore" question.** It grounds the need for a sequence in the student's own inbox behaviour.
- **Common misconception:** students think more touches always means more pressure and risk annoying the buyer. Reframe: varied, valuable touches are professional; repeated identical ones are annoying.
- **Common question:** "What if someone replies after touch two, do I still send touch three?" Answer: no, a sequence stops the moment a genuine reply arrives; the remaining touches only fire if there has been silence.
- **Classroom activity:** the three-version touch-three rewrite in the mini challenge works well as a live class vote on which version lands best.
- **Watch for:** students defaulting back to a single channel throughout, skipping the channel-switch step out of habit or comfort.

Module 10 · The setter's job & pipeline KPIs

Lesson title

The setter's job: pipeline creation, not "calling people"

Lesson overview

Defines the setter's job precisely: moving a technology opportunity from Find through Start to a qualified handoff. Introduces the nine metrics setters are measured on and the discipline of diagnosing the weakest rate before increasing raw activity.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. State the setter's job in one sentence.
2. Calculate all nine setter KPIs from raw numbers.
3. Diagnose the weakest rate in a given month's figures.
4. Explain why volume must never be increased before the weakest rate is fixed.

Real-world motivation

Tell the class about two SDRs at a Nigerian SaaS company given the same target account list. One sent three hundred messages and booked six meetings, two of which showed. The other sent one hundred and forty messages and booked eleven meetings, nine of which showed. The manager initially praised the first SDR's "hustle." Ask the class which one was actually doing the job better.

Key concepts

Concept 1: The one-sentence job definition

Definition. Move the right technology opportunity from Find to a qualified handoff.

Simple explanation. "Right" means fit against the ICP. "Qualified handoff" means the next person receives something real, not just a name.

Concept 2: The nine metrics

Definition. Response time, contact rate, engagement rate, qualification rate, appointment rate, show rate, follow-up completion, SLA compliance, and qualified opportunities created.

Simple explanation. Each metric answers a different question about where the pipeline is leaking. A setter who can diagnose from these nine sounds like a professional in any interview.

Concept 3: Rate before volume

Definition. Fixing the weakest rate always comes before increasing activity.

Simple explanation. More outreach through a broken step in the pipeline produces more waste at that step, not more revenue.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will calculate all nine metrics from a raw data set and diagnose the single weakest link.

Requirements

- A raw numbers sheet: accounts contacted, replied, qualified, booked, showed
- A calculator or spreadsheet

Step 1 · Calculate contact rate

Contacted divided by total accounts targeted.

Step 2 · Calculate engagement rate

Replied divided by contacted.

Step 3 · Calculate qualification rate

Qualified divided by engaged.

Step 4 · Calculate appointment and show rates

Booked divided by qualified; showed divided by booked.

Step 5 · Compare against the healthy range table and name the weakest rate

Students write one sentence naming the specific action that would fix the weakest rate, not a general instruction to work harder.

Testing

How to check the work: the proposed fix must target the specific weak rate identified.

Expected result: all nine metrics calculated, one rate correctly identified as weakest, one specific fix proposed.

Common errors: dividing by the wrong denominator; proposing more outreach volume regardless of which rate is actually weak.

Final output

A completed KPI diagnosis sheet, narratable aloud in under ninety seconds.

Reflection

- Which rate was weakest, and was that surprising?
- Why would "send more messages" have been the wrong fix here?

Business case study · the SDR who looked busier and performed worse

Problem. A SaaS company's manager was about to reassign accounts based on visible activity, favouring the higher-volume SDR.

Current manual process. Performance assessed by message volume, not measured conversion.

What the process is actually costing. The lower-volume, higher-converting SDR was about to be deprioritised despite producing nine shown meetings against the other's two.

The fix taught in this course. Measuring and comparing actual KPI performance instead of visible effort.

Estimated revenue recovered. Retained and correctly credited the SDR actually producing qualified pipeline.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Build a personal KPI board and begin weekly tracking.

Instructions. Create a sheet with all nine metrics as columns. Log real or practice numbers weekly starting this week.

Deliverables. Week one's completed row.

Success criteria. All nine metrics correctly calculated with the weakest identified.

Mini challenge

Given a second raw data set, diagnose it in under ninety seconds while timed, narrating your reasoning aloud.

Knowledge check · Module 10

Show the five questions and answers

1. State the setter's job in one sentence.

Answer: Move the right technology opportunity from Find to a qualified handoff.

2. What is appointment rate calculated as?

Answer: Booked divided by qualified.

3. Why must rate be fixed before volume is increased?

Answer: More outreach through a broken step produces more waste at that step, not more revenue.

4. In the two-SDR case, what was measured incorrectly?

Answer: Visible message volume was rewarded instead of actual conversion performance.

5. What makes a setter sound professional in an interview?

Answer: Being able to state specific rates and diagnoses, not describing effort.

Instructor notes · Module 10

- **Estimated teaching time:** 75 minutes theory, 60 minutes diagnosis practical.
- **Open by asking who the class thinks outperformed.** The "obviously harder worker" is the wrong guess, which is the hook.
- **Common misconception:** students conflate busyness with performance.
- **Common question:** "What if my rates look bad because of a poor target list, not my own skill?" Answer: that is a valid diagnosis, and naming it precisely is the skill being taught.
- **Classroom activity:** timed ninety-second narration as a rapid-fire round.
- **Watch for:** students defaulting to a generic "try harder" fix instead of a targeted one.

Module 11 · The first response & channel mastery for tech buyers

Lesson title

The first response: speed, relevance and reading technology-buyer channel etiquette

Lesson overview

Speed and relevance in the first reply, adapted specifically to how technology buyers behave on LinkedIn and email, which differs meaningfully from consumer WhatsApp behaviour.

Covers the etiquette differences that mark a message as credible or as spam in a professional technology context.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Explain why response time matters more in the first hour than at any later point.
2. Identify LinkedIn and email etiquette differences from WhatsApp etiquette.
3. Write a fast, relevant first reply to an inbound technology-buyer enquiry.
4. Avoid the specific first-message mistakes that mark outreach as spam to a technical audience.

Real-world motivation

Ask the class: on LinkedIn, what makes a connection request or message feel like spam within the first two seconds? Let several answer. Most will describe a generic, unpersonalised, overly salesy opener. That instinct is correct, and this lesson formalises it into a repeatable standard.

Key concepts

Concept 1: Speed still matters, differently

Definition. A fast reply to an inbound technology enquiry still outperforms a slow one, though "fast" on LinkedIn or email means hours, not the minutes expected on WhatsApp.

Simple explanation. Match the channel's own rhythm. A same-day LinkedIn reply is fast; a same-day WhatsApp reply is often already too slow.

Concept 2: LinkedIn etiquette

Definition. Connection request without an immediate pitch, a short first message once connected, and no more than one follow-up before backing off.

Simple explanation. LinkedIn users can see a profile before replying; a message that reads like a stranger who has not looked at their profile at all reads as spam immediately.

Concept 3: Email etiquette for technology buyers

Definition. A specific subject line naming the buyer's likely problem, a short body, and a single clear next step.

Simple explanation. Technical buyers receive high email volume and scan aggressively. Length and vagueness are both penalised.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will write and time a fast, relevant first response to three inbound technology-buyer scenarios across three channels.

Requirements

- Three inbound enquiry scenarios (LinkedIn, email, WhatsApp), provided by the instructor
- A stopwatch

Step 1 · Read the LinkedIn scenario and draft a reply

Time how long drafting takes; aim for a reply that references the enquiry specifically.

Step 2 · Read the email scenario and draft a reply

Include a specific subject line and one clear next step.

Step 3 · Read the WhatsApp scenario and draft a reply

Apply the speed and brevity standard from earlier modules.

Step 4 · Swap all three with a partner

The partner rates each for speed-appropriateness and channel etiquette.

Step 5 · Revise based on partner feedback

Correct any reply that felt off for its channel.

Testing

How to check the work: the partner should be able to identify which channel each reply was written for without being told.

Expected result: three genuinely distinct, channel-appropriate replies.

Common errors: writing a LinkedIn-style formal reply for WhatsApp, or a WhatsApp-style casual reply for a technical email enquiry.

Final output

Three timed, channel-appropriate first responses, added to the student's script library.

Reflection

- Which channel's etiquette felt least natural to you?
- What specifically made a reply feel like spam versus genuine?

Business case study · the LinkedIn message that read as spam

Problem. A junior SDR at an AI startup was sending the identical LinkedIn connection message to every prospect, with no reference to their profile.

Current manual process. One template, copy-pasted at volume.

What the process is actually costing. A connection acceptance rate under ten percent, and several prospects reporting the messages as spam.

The fix taught in this course. Adding one line referencing something specific and true from the prospect's own profile before any pitch.

Estimated revenue recovered. Connection acceptance rate more than doubled once messages stopped reading as templated.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Audit personal LinkedIn or email outreach for etiquette violations.

Instructions. Review ten real or practice outreach messages you have sent or drafted. Mark any that would read as spam to a technical buyer and rewrite them.

Deliverables. The audit and rewrites.

Success criteria. Every rewritten message references something specific to the recipient.

Mini challenge

Write the worst possible LinkedIn opener you can think of, then rewrite it as the best possible version, and explain each specific change.

Knowledge check · Module 11

Show the five questions and answers

1. Why does "fast" mean something different on LinkedIn than on WhatsApp?

Answer: Each channel has its own expected rhythm; a same-day LinkedIn reply is fast, while a same-day WhatsApp reply is often already too slow.

2. What makes a LinkedIn message read as spam?

Answer: A generic message that does not reference anything specific from the recipient's visible profile.

3. What should a technology-buyer email subject line contain?

Answer: A specific reference to the buyer's likely problem, not the sender's company name.

4. In the LinkedIn case, what specifically fixed the low acceptance rate?

Answer: Adding one line referencing something specific and true from the prospect's own profile.

5. Why do technical buyers penalise long, vague emails more than other audiences might?

Answer: They receive high email volume and scan aggressively, so length and vagueness both reduce the chance of a reply.

Instructor notes · Module 11

- **Estimated teaching time:** 45 minutes theory, 75 minutes multi-channel practical.
- **Open with the "what makes it feel like spam" question.** Students already have good instincts here; the lesson formalises them.
- **Common misconception:** students think one strong template can be reused unchanged across LinkedIn, email and WhatsApp.
- **Common question:** "How specific does the personalisation really need to be?" Answer: specific enough that it could only have been written for this one recipient, not a category of recipients.
- **Classroom activity:** the channel-guessing swap exercise works well as a paired activity with a class-wide tally of accuracy.
- **Watch for:** students who personalise the opening line well but let the rest of the message revert to generic template language.

Module 12 · Qualification for technology sales

Lesson title

Qualification for technology sales: Fit, Need, Authority, Timeline

Lesson overview

A technology-specific qualification framework built on Fit, Need, Authority and Timeline, sequenced to establish a real problem and its cost before budget is discussed. Includes the specific technology-sales qualifiers current tooling and integration constraints add to a standard qualification conversation.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Run a full Fit, Need, Authority, Timeline qualification sequence.
2. Ask about current tooling without sounding like an interrogation.
3. Distinguish a genuine technology need from a vague want.
4. Decide honestly whether to disqualify a prospect who fails multiple criteria.

Real-world motivation

Ask the class: if a prospect says "we're interested, send us a proposal" after a five-minute call with no other information gathered, should the setter send one? Most will hesitate. That hesitation is correct, and this lesson gives the structure to act on it properly instead of guessing.

Key concepts

Concept 1: Fit

Definition. Whether the prospect's situation genuinely matches the ICP and the product's actual capability.

Simple explanation. A prospect can be enthusiastic and still be a poor fit; enthusiasm is not evidence of fit.

Concept 2: Need, tested against current tooling

Definition. A genuine, costly problem, tested by asking what the prospect currently uses and why it is not solving the problem already.

Simple explanation. "What are you using now, and what's not working about it" surfaces a real need far more reliably than "do you need this."

Concept 3: Authority and Timeline

Definition. Authority confirms who can actually approve a purchase; Timeline confirms whether a real date drives the decision.

Simple explanation. Both must be tested honestly. A prospect with no named approver and no real date is not yet a qualified opportunity, regardless of how positive the conversation felt.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will run a full Fit, Need, Authority, Timeline qualification call in pairs and score themselves.

Requirements

- A partner playing a technology buyer with a privately decided situation
- The qualification sequence reference sheet

Step 1 · Open and test Fit

Confirm the prospect's situation genuinely matches the ICP.

Step 2 · Test Need against current tooling

Ask what they currently use and what is not working about it.

Step 3 · Test Authority

Ask who else would need to approve the purchase.

Step 4 · Test Timeline

Ask whether a specific date or event drives the decision.

Step 5 · Score and decide

If two or more criteria come back weak, practise a graceful disqualification instead of proceeding.

Testing

How to check the work: after the call, the interviewer should be able to state a real answer, not a guess, for all four letters.

Expected result: a completed scorecard with a genuine answer for each criterion and a clear proceed-or-disqualify decision.

Common errors: accepting "we're interested" as evidence of Need without asking about current tooling.

Final output

A scored qualification call with a documented decision.

Reflection

- Which criterion was hardest to get a genuine answer for?
- Did enthusiasm in the conversation match the actual qualification result?

Business case study · the proposal sent after five minutes

Problem. A setter at a workflow automation company sent a full proposal after a five-minute call where the prospect said only "we're interested, send something over."

Current manual process. No qualification requirement before proposal generation.

What the process is actually costing. Hours spent on a customised proposal for a prospect with no confirmed budget authority, who went quiet immediately after receiving it.

The fix taught in this course. Running the full Fit, Need, Authority, Timeline sequence before any proposal is generated.

Estimated time saved. Proposal-writing hours redirected to genuinely qualified opportunities.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Run and record a real qualification call with a person outside class.

Instructions. Ask a friend or colleague to play a technology buyer. Run the full four-criterion sequence.

Deliverables. Completed scorecard.

Success criteria. A genuine answer recorded for all four criteria.

Mini challenge

Write a graceful disqualification script for a prospect who fails Authority and Timeline but is genuinely enthusiastic. Deliver it to a partner and ask whether it felt respectful.

Knowledge check · Module 12

Show the five questions and answers

1. What do the four qualification criteria stand for?

Answer: Fit, Need, Authority, Timeline.

2. What question tests Need more reliably than "do you need this"?

Answer: "What are you using now, and what's not working about it."

3. Why is enthusiasm not evidence of Fit?

Answer: A prospect can be genuinely enthusiastic while still not matching the ICP or the product's actual capability.

4. In the proposal case, what was skipped that should not have been?

Answer: The full qualification sequence, before hours were spent on a customised proposal.

5. What should happen if two or more criteria come back weak?

Answer: A graceful disqualification or a move to nurture, rather than proceeding as if the opportunity were qualified.

Instructor notes · Module 12

- **Estimated teaching time:** 75 minutes theory, 60 minutes paired practical.
- **Open with the five-minute proposal question.** Let the class's hesitation do the work before teaching the framework.
- **Common misconception:** students think qualification is about filtering people out unkindly. Reframe as protecting both sides' time.
- **Common question:** "What if I never get a straight answer on Authority?" Answer: a dodged Authority question is itself useful information; note it honestly rather than assuming the best case.
- **Classroom activity:** fishbowl one pair's call in front of the class, followed by group scoring.

- **Watch for:** students skipping the current-tooling question because it feels less exciting than talking about the new product.

Module 13 · Appointment setting & show-rate systems

Lesson title

Appointment setting: booking a demo a technology buyer actually attends

Lesson overview

The framing paragraph, the two-named-times booking ask, and the four-message show-up sequence that moves show rates from roughly a third to close to four in five, applied specifically to booking technology product demos and discovery calls.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Write a framing paragraph before any demo booking ask.
2. Offer two specific times instead of an open question.
3. Run the full four-message show-up sequence for a demo booking.
4. Explain why each of the four messages does a distinct job.

Real-world motivation

Tell the class about a SaaS company whose demo show rate rose from roughly a third to close to four in five without changing anything about the demo itself, purely by adding framing, confirmation, a reminder and a same-day nudge around the booking.

Key concepts

Concept 1: The framing paragraph, for a demo specifically

Definition. One clear sentence stating what the demo will show and why it matters to this specific buyer's confirmed problem.

Simple explanation. "I'll show you exactly how this handles the overnight lead-loss problem you mentioned" earns far more attention than a bare "can we book a demo."

Concept 2: Two named times

Definition. Offering exactly two specific time options rather than an open question.

Simple explanation. A busy technical buyer chooses between two options faster than they check a calendar to answer an open question.

Concept 3: The four-message sequence

Definition. Framing and ask, immediate confirmation with prep questions, a day-before reminder, and a same-day nudge.

Simple explanation. Each message removes one more reason a busy buyer's calendar quietly forgets the meeting.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will write and sequence the full four-message show-up system for a demo booking.

Requirements

- A qualified prospect scenario from Module 12

Step 1 · Write the framing paragraph

Tied to the specific problem confirmed during qualification.

Step 2 · Write the booking ask with two named times

Attached directly to the framing paragraph.

Step 3 · Write the confirmation message

Including one specific preparation question for the buyer.

Step 4 · Write the day-before reminder

Reinforcing the specific value the demo will deliver.

Step 5 · Write the same-day nudge

Short, referencing something specific already discussed.

Testing

How to check the work: remove any one message and check whether the sequence still feels complete.

Expected result: a complete four-message sequence, each doing a distinct job.

Common errors: offering an open "whenever works" instead of two named times.

Final output

A complete written show-up sequence for a technology demo booking.

Reflection

- Which message felt most important to a busy technical buyer specifically?
- How did tying the framing paragraph to a confirmed problem change its tone?

Business case study · the demo show rate that doubled

Problem. A SaaS company's demo show rate sat around a third, wasting significant sales engineering time on no-shows.

Current manual process. A single booking message with no framing, confirmation, reminder or nudge.

What the process is actually costing. Sales engineering time booked and wasted on unattended demos.

The fix taught in this course. Adding the four-message sequence, changing nothing about the demo content itself.

Estimated revenue recovered. Show rate rose from roughly a third to close to four in five, more than doubling qualified conversations actually held.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Run the full four-message sequence on a real booked meeting.

Instructions. The next time you genuinely book any meeting, real or practice, run all four messages adapted to the situation.

Deliverables. The four sent messages and the outcome.

Success criteria. All four messages sent in the correct order and timing.

Mini challenge

Write a no-show recovery message for a technology buyer who misses a demo despite the full sequence, reopening the conversation without shaming them.

Knowledge check · Module 13

Show the five questions and answers

1. What must a demo framing paragraph connect to?

Answer: The specific problem confirmed during qualification, not a generic description of the product.

2. Why offer two named times rather than an open question?

Answer: A busy buyer chooses between two options faster than checking a calendar to answer an open question.

3. Name the four messages in the show-up sequence.

Answer: Framing and ask, immediate confirmation, day-before reminder, same-day nudge.

4. In the SaaS company case, what specifically changed to raise the show rate?

Answer: Adding framing, confirmation, reminder and nudge messages, with no change to the demo itself.

5. What does the confirmation message add beyond confirming the time?

Answer: One specific preparation question for the buyer.

Instructor notes · Module 13

- **Estimated teaching time:** 60 minutes theory, 60 minutes sequence-writing practical.
- **Open with the show-rate figure before explaining the fix.** Let the class guess what changed on the call itself before revealing nothing did.
- **Common misconception:** students think a reminder and a nudge are the same and can be merged.
- **Common question:** "Won't a busy technical buyer find four messages excessive?"
Answer: each has a distinct, respectful purpose, and the case study shows removing any one measurably hurts show rate.
- **Classroom activity:** remove-one-message test as a class discussion.
- **Watch for:** students defaulting to an open "let me know what time works" out of habit.

Module 14 · The handoff to a closer

Lesson title

The handoff: transferring trust on a technology deal, not just information

Lesson overview

A buyer who has built context with a setter does not want to re-explain their technical situation to a stranger. This module teaches the full handoff format and the three-question

test, and closes with the scored checkpoint that assigns each student to the Setter or Closer track.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Write a complete handoff note including the buyer's current tooling and technical context.
2. Apply the three-question test to any handoff.
3. Explain why a poor handoff costs qualified technology opportunities specifically.
4. Open a closing or demo call using only information from a handoff note.

Real-world motivation

Tell the class about a deal where a setter had uncovered that a prospect's real frustration was a specific integration failure with their existing CRM. The handoff to the closer mentioned only "interested in automation," and the closer opened the demo with a generic walkthrough. The prospect visibly disengaged within two minutes, still waiting for the CRM integration problem to be addressed.

Key concepts

Concept 1: A handoff transfers trust, not just data

Definition. A properly written handoff lets the closer open with something only a well-briefed person would know, including the buyer's current tooling and specific technical concern.

Simple explanation. This signals instantly that the buyer is being handled by a coordinated team.

Concept 2: The three-question test, for technology deals

Definition. Does the closer know why the buyer is here, what technical context and current tooling they described, and what specifically worries them?

Simple explanation. A handoff missing the technical context specifically is a common and costly gap in technology sales handoffs.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will write a complete handoff note including technical context and have a partner open a demo call using only that note.

Requirements

- A real or simulated setter conversation transcript from Module 12's qualification call

- The handoff format reference sheet

Step 1 · Extract why the buyer is here and their real driver

From Module 7's driver-mapping work if available.

Step 2 · Extract current tooling and technical context

What they use now and what specifically is not working.

Step 3 · Extract the buyer's main worry

In their own words if possible.

Step 4 · Write the full handoff note

Combining all elements into the complete format.

Step 5 · Hand to a partner with no other context to open a demo call

Score the opening against the three-question test.

Testing

How to check the work: if the opening sounds generic rather than referencing the specific technical context, the handoff was not specific enough.

Expected result: a handoff that lets a partner open convincingly, referencing something only a well-briefed person would know.

Common errors: omitting current tooling and technical context in favour of only surface-level facts.

Final output

A complete handoff note plus a recorded or observed opening that passes the three-question test.

Reflection

- What technical detail, if any, was missing from your first handoff draft?
- How would a buyer likely react to hearing their specific integration problem referenced immediately?

Business case study · the demo that opened generically and lost the deal

Problem. A closer opened a demo generically after receiving a handoff that omitted the buyer's specific CRM integration frustration.

Current manual process. Handoffs recorded only the surface reason for interest, not technical context.

What the process is actually costing. The buyer disengaged within two minutes, still waiting for their actual problem to be addressed.

The fix taught in this course. A handoff format that mandatorily includes current tooling and the specific technical concern.

Estimated revenue recovered. Subsequent handoffs using the full format saw demo engagement improve measurably in the opening minutes.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Write three real or realistic technical handoffs and test each with a different partner.

Instructions. Using real or simulated setter conversations, write three complete handoffs including technical context. Test each with a different partner opening a call.

Deliverables. The three notes and resulting openings.

Success criteria. All three openings reference specific technical context, not generic language.

Mini challenge

Take your weakest handoff, identify exactly what technical detail was missing, and rewrite it.

Knowledge check · Module 14

Show the five questions and answers

1. What must a technology-sales handoff include beyond the general three-question test?

Answer: The buyer's current tooling and specific technical concern.

2. In the CRM integration case, what was missing from the handoff?

Answer: The buyer's specific integration frustration, replaced with only a generic "interested in automation" note.

3. Why does a technical-context gap in a handoff cost more in technology sales specifically?

Answer: Technology buyers expect their specific technical situation to be understood immediately; a generic opening signals the seller was not actually listening.

4. What happens at the end of Module 14 in the DSS programme?

Answer: Students are assigned to the Setter or Closer track based on a scored checkpoint.

5. How can a handoff's quality be tested before a real call?

Answer: Have a partner with no other context open a call using only the note, and check whether the opening references something specific.

Instructor notes · Module 14

- **Estimated teaching time:** 45 minutes theory, 60 minutes handoff practical, 45 minutes track-assignment checkpoint.
- **Open with the disengaged-buyer story.** Let the class feel the cost of a generic opening before teaching the fix.
- **Common misconception:** students think a handoff is a summary of facts. Reframe as a trust and technical-context transfer.
- **Common question:** "What if the setter never uncovered the technical context?" Answer: that is itself a signal the qualification in Module 12 was not deep enough; flag it honestly in the handoff rather than inventing detail.
- **Classroom activity:** the blind-opening exercise is the most effective way to expose a weak handoff quickly.
- **Watch for:** handoffs that are long but vague on the one thing that matters most: the specific technical concern.

Module 15 · Discovery for technology sales

Lesson title

Discovery for technology sales: Situation, Problem, Impact, Desired Outcome, Solution Fit

Lesson overview

The heaviest-weighted competency in the DSS Sales Readiness Index. Students learn the five-stage discovery structure and the discipline of staying in one area of enquiry past the first, comfortable answer until it becomes concrete enough to build a real recommendation on.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Run a full Situation, Problem, Impact, Desired Outcome, Solution Fit discovery sequence.
2. Ask at least three follow-up questions inside one area before moving on.
3. Quantify a technical problem's cost in the buyer's own words.
4. Decide honestly whether Solution Fit is genuine before proceeding to a demo.

Real-world motivation

Ask the class: if a buyer says "our current process is slow," is that useful information? Let them sit with the question. It is not, yet, because slow compared to what, slow in which specific step, and slow with what actual consequence are all still unknown. This lesson is about staying in the question until it becomes useful.

Key concepts

Concept 1: Situation and Problem

Definition. Situation establishes the buyer's current state and tooling; Problem establishes specifically what is not working.

Simple explanation. Both must be concrete before moving to Impact, or the cost calculation that follows will be a guess.

Concept 2: Impact

Definition. The quantified cost of the problem, in the buyer's own words wherever possible.

Simple explanation. "How much is that costing you, roughly" turns a vague complaint into a number the buyer will defend later when justifying the purchase internally.

Concept 3: Desired Outcome and Solution Fit

Definition. Desired Outcome is what the buyer wants instead; Solution Fit is an honest check of whether the product can actually deliver it.

Simple explanation. Solution Fit is not assumed. A closer who cannot honestly confirm fit should say so rather than proceeding to a demo that will disappoint.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will run a full five-stage discovery call, staying in each area at least three questions deep.

Requirements

- A partner playing a technology buyer with a realistic situation
- A discovery worksheet with the five stages as headers

Step 1 · Establish Situation

Current tooling and process, in specific detail.

Step 2 · Establish Problem, three questions deep

Do not accept the first answer; ask "what specifically" and "how often" before moving on.

Step 3 · Quantify Impact

Push for a number or a concrete consequence, not a vague acknowledgement.

Step 4 · Establish Desired Outcome

What the buyer wants instead, in their own words.

Step 5 · Honestly assess Solution Fit

Decide and state whether the product can genuinely deliver the desired outcome.

Testing

How to check the work: the Problem stage should show at least three follow-up questions in the transcript, not one question and one answer.

Expected result: a completed five-stage discovery transcript with a quantified Impact and an honest Solution Fit assessment.

Common errors: accepting a vague first answer and moving on; skipping Solution Fit and assuming it.

Final output

A completed discovery transcript, used again in Module 16's demo practical.

Reflection

- How different was the third answer in the Problem stage from the first?

- Was Solution Fit genuinely confirmed, or assumed?

Business case study · the eleven-minute answer

Problem. A closer at a workflow automation company asked a manufacturing client "what's slow about your current process" and received a one-sentence answer: "it just takes too long."

Current manual process. Accepting the one-sentence answer and moving directly to a product pitch.

What the process is actually costing. A demo built on a guess about what "too long" actually meant, which failed to connect with the buyer's real bottleneck.

The fix taught in this course. Staying in the Problem stage for eleven more minutes of specific follow-up questions, eventually uncovering that the real bottleneck was a fifteen-minute manual approval step occurring dozens of times a day.

Estimated revenue recovered. The subsequent demo, rebuilt around the fifteen-minute approval bottleneck specifically, closed within the same week.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Run two more five-stage discovery calls with different partners.

Instructions. Repeat the practical with two new partners and two different realistic situations.

Deliverables. Two completed discovery transcripts.

Success criteria. Both show at least three follow-up questions in the Problem stage and a quantified Impact.

Mini challenge

Take a one-sentence problem statement ("it's inefficient") and write five follow-up questions that would deepen it into something concrete, without ever asking "why" directly.

Knowledge check · Module 15

Show the five questions and answers

1. Name the five stages of technology-sales discovery.

Answer: Situation, Problem, Impact, Desired Outcome, Solution Fit.

2. Why is a one-sentence problem statement not yet useful?

Answer: It does not specify what, how often, or with what consequence, making any recommendation built on it a guess.

3. What does Impact require beyond acknowledging a problem exists?

Answer: A quantified cost, in the buyer's own words wherever possible.

4. In the manufacturing case, what was the real bottleneck eventually uncovered?

Answer: A fifteen-minute manual approval step occurring dozens of times a day.

5. What should a closer do if Solution Fit is honestly unclear?

Answer: Say so, rather than proceeding to a demo built on an assumed fit.

Instructor notes · Module 15

- **Estimated teaching time:** 60 minutes theory, 90 minutes discovery practical.
- **Open with the "our process is slow" question.** Let the class recognise how little that sentence actually tells them.
- **Common misconception:** students think asking more questions risks annoying the buyer. Reframe: staying in the problem shows genuine interest, not interrogation, when done with real curiosity.
- **Common question:** "How do I know when I've asked enough follow-up questions?"
Answer: when the answer becomes something you could act on, a specific number or a specific step, not before.
- **Classroom activity:** fishbowl one discovery call, timing how long the pair stays in the Problem stage before moving on.
- **Watch for:** students who ask good follow-up questions but then skip straight past Solution Fit at the end.

Module 16 · Product demonstration: demo the outcome, not the feature

Lesson title

Product demonstration: showing the outcome discovery actually surfaced

Lesson overview

The core discipline of technology sales demos: never open with a button, always open with the specific business outcome discovery surfaced. Students run a live demo of a real or simulated SaaS product, judged on whether it connects to the buyer's stated problem within the first ninety seconds.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Open a demo with the buyer's specific outcome, not a feature tour.
2. Structure a demo around three features maximum, each tied to something discovery surfaced.
3. Avoid narrating unrelated features "while we're here."
4. Close a demo with a specific next step.

Real-world motivation

Play or describe two demo openings for the same product. One starts: "So let me walk you through the dashboard, here's the homepage, here's settings." The other starts: "You told me the fifteen-minute approval step is your biggest bottleneck, let me show you exactly what happens to that step here." Ask the class which one keeps a buyer's attention past the first thirty seconds.

Key concepts

Concept 1: Demo the outcome

Definition. Opening a demo by restating the buyer's specific discovered problem and showing exactly how the product addresses it, before any general tour.

Simple explanation. A demo is not a tour of the product. It is proof that discovery was real and the product actually solves what was found.

Concept 2: Three features maximum

Definition. Limiting a demo to the features directly tied to the buyer's discovered problem, resisting the urge to show everything the product does.

Simple explanation. Every feature shown that is not tied to the buyer's problem dilutes the ones that are, and risks introducing a new objection about something the buyer never asked for.

Concept 3: Closing a demo with a next step

Definition. Ending the demo with a specific, proposed next action, not an open "any questions?"

Simple explanation. A demo without a proposed next step often ends with polite interest and no forward motion.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will deliver a live demo built entirely around the discovery transcript from Module 15, timed to open with the buyer's outcome within ninety seconds.

Requirements

- The Module 15 discovery transcript
- A real or simulated product to demo (screen share or described walkthrough)
- A stopwatch

Step 1 · Write the ninety-second opening

Restating the buyer's specific problem and impact from discovery.

Step 2 · Select exactly three features to show

Each directly tied to something discovery surfaced.

Step 3 · Deliver the demo live, timed

A partner times the opening to confirm it lands within ninety seconds.

Step 4 · Close with a specific next step

Not "any questions," but a proposed specific action.

Step 5 · Partner feedback

The partner notes whether any feature shown felt disconnected from the discovered problem.

Testing

How to check the work: the opening ninety seconds must reference the specific discovered problem, not a general product description.

Expected result: a timed demo opening within ninety seconds, three tied features, and a specific closing next step.

Common errors: opening with a general product tour before reaching the buyer's problem; showing a fourth "while we're here" feature.

Final output

A delivered, timed demo with partner feedback recorded.

Reflection

- Did any feature you showed feel disconnected from the buyer's actual problem?
- How did opening with the outcome change the buyer partner's attention compared to a generic tour?

Business case study · the forty-minute demo that lost the deal

Problem. A sales engineer at a SaaS company ran a full forty-minute feature tour for a prospect whose discovery had surfaced one specific, narrow problem.

Current manual process. A standard demo script covering every major feature, regardless of what discovery had found.

What the process is actually costing. The buyer disengaged after the first fifteen minutes, having already seen what they came for and now sitting through unrelated content.

The fix taught in this course. Cutting the demo to the three features tied to the discovered problem, opening with the outcome directly.

Estimated revenue recovered. Demo length dropped to under fifteen minutes with measurably higher engagement and follow-up rate.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Deliver two more outcome-first demos for different discovery transcripts.

Instructions. Repeat the practical with two new discovery scenarios, timing each opening.

Deliverables. Two delivered demos with timing and partner feedback.

Success criteria. Both openings land within ninety seconds and reference the specific discovered problem.

Mini challenge

Take a generic feature description ("automated reporting") and write the outcome-first opening line that would connect it to three different discovered problems, one at a time.

Knowledge check · Module 16

Show the five questions and answers

1. What should a demo open with?

Answer: The buyer's specific discovered problem and how the product addresses it, not a general product tour.

2. How many features should a demo show, maximum?

Answer: Three, each directly tied to the buyer's discovered problem.

3. Why does showing an unrelated "while we're here" feature hurt a demo?

Answer: It dilutes the features that matter and risks introducing a new objection about something the buyer never asked for.

4. In the forty-minute demo case, what specifically fixed the disengagement?

Answer: Cutting to three tied features and opening with the outcome directly, instead of a full feature tour.

5. How should a demo close?

Answer: With a specific proposed next step, not an open "any questions."

Instructor notes · Module 16

- **Estimated teaching time:** 45 minutes theory, 105 minutes live demo practical.
- **Open with the two-opening comparison.** Let the class feel the difference before teaching the principle.
- **Common misconception:** students think a longer, more thorough demo is always more impressive. Correct directly with the forty-minute case.
- **Common question:** "What if the buyer asks about a feature I didn't plan to show?"
Answer: answer briefly and honestly, then return to the planned three, using the answer-and-return technique from earlier modules.
- **Classroom activity:** timed live demos in front of the class work well, with the group scoring the ninety-second opening specifically.
- **Watch for:** students who write a strong ninety-second opening but then drift into an untied feature tour once the demo is actually running.

Module 17 · Value selling: feature to financial impact

Lesson title

Value selling: the Feature, Capability, Business Value, Financial Impact ladder

Lesson overview

Almost every closer knows benefits matter more than features and still slides back into feature talk under pressure. This module drills the ladder until translating a feature into a business or financial outcome becomes automatic.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Climb the Feature to Financial Impact ladder for any technology feature.
2. Distinguish business value from financial impact.
3. Land the ladder on something specific to the buyer, not a generic claim.
4. Choose the right kind of value (business outcome versus personal) for a given buyer.

Real-world motivation

Write on the board: "AI-automated follow-up." Ask the class what that actually means for a business. Most will describe the feature again in different words. Then walk the ladder live: automated follow-up, which means no lead goes more than a day without contact, which means qualified-to-booked rate improves, which means the sales team closes more of what marketing is already generating. That is the skill this lesson builds.

Key concepts

Concept 1: The four rungs

Definition. Feature (what it is), Capability (what it lets you do), Business Value (what changes for the business), Financial Impact (what that is worth in money or measurable outcome).

Simple explanation. A closer who stops at Feature or Capability is still describing the product. Business Value and Financial Impact are what actually justify a purchase decision.

Concept 2: Landing on something specific

Definition. The top rung should connect to something the specific buyer already stated they care about, from discovery.

Simple explanation. A generic "which means more revenue" is weaker than a specific rung tied to the buyer's own stated pain, because the buyer has to do less work to see themselves in it.

Concept 3: Business value versus personal value

Definition. Business value is what changes for the company; personal value is how the decision affects the individual buyer, their workload, their standing with their own manager.

Simple explanation. Sometimes personal value matters more to the actual human deciding, even in a B2B purchase. Skilled closers listen for which kind of value the buyer keeps returning to.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will climb the ladder for five real technology features, at least three rungs deep each.

Requirements

- Five technology features, provided by the instructor or drawn from Module 16's demo
- A ladder worksheet with four rows per feature

Step 1 · Write the Feature

State it exactly as the product describes it.

Step 2 · Write the Capability

What it lets the user actually do.

Step 3 · Write the Business Value

What changes for the business as a result.

Step 4 · Write the Financial Impact

What that is worth, in money or a measurable outcome.

Step 5 · Repeat for all five features, then tie one to a specific buyer

Using the Module 15 discovery transcript, rewrite one ladder so its top rung connects to that specific buyer's stated pain.

Testing

How to check the work: the Financial Impact rung must be concrete (a number, a measurable outcome), not a vague claim like "more efficient."

Expected result: five completed four-rung ladders, with one explicitly tied to a specific buyer.

Common errors: stopping at Capability and calling it Business Value; writing a Financial Impact rung too generic to be believable.

Final output

Five completed ladders, added to the student's value-selling reference library.

Reflection

- Which feature was hardest to climb past Capability?
- Did any feature's real value turn out to be personal rather than purely business?

Business case study · the feature nobody could explain the value of

Problem. A cybersecurity company's sales team consistently described a key feature, "automated threat scoring," without ever explaining what it meant for the buyer's business.

Current manual process. Sales conversations stopped at Capability: "it automatically scores threats by severity."

What the process is actually costing. Buyers heard a technical description with no connection to their own priorities and treated the feature as unremarkable.

The fix taught in this course. Climbing the full ladder: automated threat scoring, which means the security team stops manually triaging hundreds of alerts, which means the two most experienced analysts spend their time on real threats instead of sorting noise, which means fewer missed incidents and lower risk of a costly breach.

Estimated revenue recovered. The feature became a stated reason for purchase in subsequent deals, rather than an unremarked-upon technical detail.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Build ladders for five more features from a different technology category.

Instructions. Choose a product in a category different from your Module 17 practical (for example, fintech instead of SaaS) and build five four-rung ladders.

Deliverables. Five completed ladders.

Success criteria. Every ladder reaches a concrete Financial Impact rung.

Mini challenge

Take one ladder and write two different top rungs: one framed as business value, one framed as personal value to the specific buyer. Explain which you would lead with and why, for a given persona.

Knowledge check · Module 17

Show the five questions and answers

1. Name the four rungs of the value-selling ladder.

Answer: Feature, Capability, Business Value, Financial Impact.

2. Why is a generic top rung weaker than a specific one?

Answer: A specific rung tied to the buyer's own stated pain requires less work from the buyer to see themselves in it.

3. What is the difference between business value and personal value?

Answer: Business value is what changes for the company; personal value is how the decision affects the individual buyer directly.

4. In the cybersecurity case, where did the sales team's explanation originally stop?

Answer: At Capability, describing what the feature does technically without climbing to Business Value or Financial Impact.

5. What makes a Financial Impact rung credible rather than vague?

Answer: A concrete number or measurable outcome, not a general claim like "more efficient."

Instructor notes · Module 17

- **Estimated teaching time:** 45 minutes theory, 90 minutes ladder-building practical.
- **Open by climbing one ladder live on the board.** Let the class watch the translation happen before asking them to do it themselves.
- **Common misconception:** students think stating the Capability clearly is the same as stating the value. It is not; push every ladder to Financial Impact.
- **Common question:** "What if I don't have a real number for Financial Impact?" Answer: use a credible estimate or a measurable outcome the buyer would recognise as real, clearly framed as an estimate.
- **Classroom activity:** assign different features to different students and build a shared class ladder reference sheet.
- **Watch for:** students who reach a plausible-sounding Business Value rung but cannot defend it if pushed with "so what does that actually save."

Module 18 · Presenting & pricing a technology solution

Lesson title

Presenting and pricing: structure, silence, and technology pricing models

Lesson overview

The eight-step presentation structure applied to technology pricing specifically: tiered pricing, seat-based pricing, usage-based pricing, and the discipline of silence after stating a number.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Run the eight-step presentation structure for a technology solution.
2. Explain tiered, seat-based and usage-based pricing to a buyer clearly.
3. Restate a buyer's problem accurately before presenting price.
4. Hold genuine silence after stating a price.

Real-world motivation

Ask the class: when you state a price and the buyer goes quiet, whose discomfort is that, really? Most assume the buyer's. It is usually the seller's own discomfort, and filling that silence with justification or an unprompted discount is one of the most common ways a closer talks a buyer out of a decision they were quietly leaning toward.

Key concepts

Concept 1: The eight-step structure, compressed for technology pricing

Definition. Restate the problem, present the recommendation tied to it, explain the pricing model, state the price, hold silence, address the first reaction, confirm next steps, close the conversation.

Simple explanation. Good discovery in Module 15 makes this presentation short. A closer who did discovery well rarely needs more than a few minutes to reach the price.

Concept 2: Technology pricing models

Definition. Tiered (feature bundles at different price points), seat-based (price scales with number of users), usage-based (price scales with consumption).

Simple explanation. Explaining which model applies, and why, prevents the single most common pricing confusion buyers raise later.

Concept 3: Silence after the number

Definition. A deliberate pause after stating price, long enough for the buyer to genuinely process it.

Simple explanation. Buyers need real time to weigh a number against their own budget. Filling that silence removes their space to think and often looks like the seller doubting their own price.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will deliver a full eight-step presentation, including pricing model explanation and a timed silence, using the Module 15 discovery and Module 17 value ladder.

Requirements

- The Module 15 discovery transcript and Module 17 value ladder
- A partner and a stopwatch

Step 1 · Restate the buyer's problem

In the buyer's own language wherever possible.

Step 2 · Present the recommendation

Tied directly to the restated problem, using the value ladder from Module 17.

Step 3 · Explain the pricing model

State clearly whether it is tiered, seat-based or usage-based, and why that fits this buyer.

Step 4 · State the price and hold silence

Time at least five full seconds of genuine silence after the number.

Step 5 · Address the buyer's first reaction

Respond to whatever the partner says first, without immediately offering a discount.

Testing

How to check the work: the partner should confirm the silence felt real, not rushed or filled early.

Expected result: a complete presentation with a restated problem, tied recommendation, clear pricing explanation, and genuine held silence.

Common errors: filling silence with justification before the buyer has spoken; explaining the pricing model in technical terms the buyer did not ask for.

Final output

A delivered, timed presentation with partner feedback.

Reflection

- How long did the silence actually feel compared to how long you guessed?

- What did the partner say once the silence was genuinely held?

Business case study · the discount offered into silence

Problem. A closer at a SaaS company stated an annual price, and after two seconds of silence, offered an unprompted fifteen percent discount before the buyer had said anything at all.

Current manual process. No discipline around holding silence after stating price.

What the process is actually costing. The buyer, who had been quietly calculating whether the original price fit their budget and was likely to say yes, instead paused to consider whether an even larger discount might be available if they pushed back.

The fix taught in this course. Holding silence for a minimum of five seconds and letting the buyer speak first, every time.

Estimated revenue recovered. Average deal value improved once reflexive, unprompted discounting stopped.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Deliver two more full presentations for different discovery scenarios.

Instructions. Repeat the eight-step practical with two new scenarios, each using a different pricing model (tiered, seat-based or usage-based).

Deliverables. Two delivered presentations with timing.

Success criteria. Both include a held silence of at least five seconds after the price.

Mini challenge

Practise stating a price and holding fifteen full seconds of silence with a partner, timed by a third person. Most students break well before fifteen seconds on the first attempt.

Knowledge check · Module 18

Show the five questions and answers

1. What comes immediately before presenting the recommendation in the eight-step structure?

Answer: Restating the buyer's problem, in their own language wherever possible.

2. Name the three technology pricing models covered.

Answer: Tiered, seat-based, usage-based.

3. Whose discomfort is the silence after a price usually reflecting?

Answer: The seller's, not the buyer's, who is generally using the time to genuinely think.

4. In the discount case, what specifically went wrong?

Answer: An unprompted discount was offered into silence before the buyer had said anything, undermining the original price.

5. How long should a closer hold silence after stating a price, at minimum?

Answer: At least five full seconds, letting the buyer speak first.

Instructor notes · Module 18

- **Estimated teaching time:** 45 minutes theory, 90 minutes presentation and silence practical.
- **Open with the "whose discomfort" question.** Let the class reconsider their own assumption before teaching the discipline.
- **Common misconception:** students believe a longer, more detailed pricing explanation sounds more professional. Correct directly: clarity and brevity build more confidence than length.
- **Common question:** "What if the silence genuinely goes on too long and feels awkward?" Answer: let it. The buyer will speak; the discomfort is rarely as long or as damaging as it feels to the seller in the moment.
- **Classroom activity:** the timed fifteen-second silence drill is one of the most viscerally useful exercises in the programme; run it live with a visible stopwatch.
- **Watch for:** students who hold silence well in practice but revert to filling it the moment a real, unscripted reaction arrives.

Module 19 · Objection handling for technology buyers

Lesson title

Objection handling: the objections technology buyers raise, and the roots underneath them

Lesson overview

The five-step objection method applied to the objections technology buyers raise specifically: "we already built something like this internally," "how do we know our data is safe," "we're locked into a competitor's contract," and "who else is using this at our scale." Students learn that identical wording can come from different roots requiring different responses.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Apply the five-step method to the four common technology objections.
2. Diagnose the real root behind an objection before responding.
3. Respond to a "build versus buy" objection without dismissing the internal team's work.
4. Respond to a security objection with proof, not reassurance alone.

Real-world motivation

Ask the class: if a prospect says "we already built something like this internally," what is the wrong first response? Most will guess correctly: arguing that the internal tool is inferior. That response puts the closer at odds with someone's own work and rarely helps. This lesson teaches the better path.

Key concepts

Concept 1: The five-step method, recapped for technology objections

Definition. Acknowledge, clarify, listen for the real objection, respond to the real thing, confirm and propose a next step.

Simple explanation. The same method from earlier modules, applied to objections specific to buying technology rather than generic products.

Concept 2: "We already built this internally"

Definition. A build-versus-buy objection, often carrying real pride in the internal team's work.

Simple explanation. The productive response asks about total cost of ownership and opportunity cost of continued internal maintenance, not the internal tool's quality directly.

Concept 3: "How do we know our data is safe"

Definition. A security objection requiring proof, not reassurance.

Simple explanation. "It's very secure" is reassurance. A specific certification, an audit reference, or a technical document is proof. Only proof actually resolves this objection.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will run the five-step method against all four common technology objections in role-play pairs.

Requirements

- A partner briefed to raise one of the four objections realistically
- The objection reference sheet

Step 1 · Partner raises "we already built this internally"

Student runs the full five-step method, diagnosing whether the real root is pride, cost concern, or genuine satisfaction with the internal tool.

Step 2 · Partner raises the data security objection

Student responds with specific proof rather than general reassurance.

Step 3 · Partner raises the competitor lock-in objection

Student asks about contract timing and switching cost without disparaging the competitor.

Step 4 · Partner raises "who else is using this at our scale"

Student responds with a specific, relevant reference rather than a vague "many customers."

Step 5 · Partner feedback on all four

Rate each response on whether it addressed the real root or just the surface wording.

Testing

How to check the work: every security-objection response must include something specific (a certification name, an audit reference), not general reassurance alone.

Expected result: four handled objections, each diagnosed for its real root before a response was given.

Common errors: dismissing the internal tool's quality directly in the build-versus-buy response; responding to the security objection with reassurance alone.

Final output

Four documented objection-response exchanges, added to the student's objection library.

Reflection

- Which objection felt hardest to respond to without becoming defensive?
- What specific proof would you need ready for the security objection in a real deal?

Business case study · the build-versus-buy objection handled wrong, then right

Problem. A closer at an automation company responded to "we built something similar internally" by listing everything the internal tool lacked compared to the product.

Current manual process. Arguing the internal tool's inferiority directly.

What the process is actually costing. The prospect, who had personally built the internal tool, became visibly defensive and the deal stalled.

The fix taught in this course. On a second, similar deal, the closer instead asked about the ongoing cost of maintaining and updating the internal tool, a question that let the prospect arrive at the total-cost-of-ownership problem themselves.

Estimated revenue recovered. The second deal progressed to a proof of concept within the same call, without the prospect feeling their own work had been criticised.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Build a personal library of six technology objections with full five-step responses.

Instructions. Beyond the four covered in class, add two more realistic technology objections and write full five-step responses.

Deliverables. A written library of six objections and responses.

Success criteria. Each response diagnoses a real root before responding, not just the surface wording.

Mini challenge

Write the specific proof pack (certification, audit reference, case study) you would want ready before facing a real data-security objection for a product you know. If you do not know the real answer, write down exactly who you would ask to find out.

Knowledge check · Module 19

Show the five questions and answers

1. What is the wrong first response to "we already built this internally"?

Answer: Arguing that the internal tool is inferior, which puts the closer at odds with the prospect's own work.

2. What resolves a data security objection: reassurance or proof?

Answer: Proof, such as a specific certification, audit reference, or technical document.

3. What question productively reframes a build-versus-buy objection?

Answer: A question about the ongoing cost of maintaining and updating the internal tool.

4. In the case study, what changed between the first and second handling of the same objection?

Answer: The closer stopped criticising the internal tool directly and instead asked about its maintenance cost, letting the prospect reach the conclusion themselves.

5. What should a response to "who else is using this at our scale" include?

Answer: A specific, relevant reference, not a vague claim like "many customers."

Instructor notes · Module 19

- **Estimated teaching time:** 60 minutes theory, 75 minutes role-play practical.
- **Open with the "what's the wrong first response" question.** Let the class's correct instinct set up the lesson.
- **Common misconception:** students think a confident, detailed rebuttal is always the strongest response. For build-versus-buy specifically, a question often works better than a rebuttal.
- **Common question:** "What if I genuinely don't have the security proof the buyer wants?" *Answer:* say so honestly and commit to getting it, exactly as the ethics standard in Module 5 requires.
- **Classroom activity:** rotate all four objections through every pair so each student practises all of them, not just one.
- **Watch for:** students who handle the wording of an objection well but never actually diagnose its real root before responding.

Module 20 · Closing technology deals

Lesson title

Closing technology deals: procurement, buying committees and proof-of-concept structures

Lesson overview

Buying signals, procurement processes, security reviews, and the closes that actually apply to a multi-stakeholder technology purchase rather than a single-buyer transaction.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Recognise genuine buying signals in a technology sales conversation.
2. Explain what a procurement process typically requires.
3. Structure a proof-of-concept or pilot with clear success criteria.
4. Close a multi-stakeholder deal without leaving any stakeholder unaddressed.

Real-world motivation

Ask the class: if a buyer says "this looks great, let's move forward," is the deal closed? Most beginners would say yes. In a real technology sale, this is often the start of procurement, not the end of the sale. This lesson teaches what actually happens between "let's move forward" and a signed contract.

Key concepts

Concept 1: Buying signals versus enthusiasm

Definition. A buying signal is a specific, actionable statement (asking about contract terms, requesting a security review, introducing a procurement contact). Enthusiasm is a positive reaction with no specific next action attached.

Simple explanation. "This looks great" is enthusiasm. "Can you send this to our procurement team" is a buying signal.

Concept 2: Procurement

Definition. The formal internal process, often involving a dedicated team, that reviews and approves a technology purchase.

Simple explanation. Procurement can involve security review, legal review, and budget approval, each potentially run by a different person the closer has not yet met.

Concept 3: Proof of concept, structured properly

Definition. A time-boxed trial with explicitly agreed success criteria set before it begins.

Simple explanation. An unstructured pilot with no agreed success criteria can run indefinitely without ever producing a decision. A properly structured one has a start date, an end date, and a specific, pre-agreed definition of success.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will structure a proof-of-concept proposal with clear success criteria for a simulated multi-stakeholder deal.

Requirements

- A simulated deal scenario with at least two stakeholders (a champion and a procurement contact)
- A proof-of-concept planning worksheet

Step 1 · Identify the buying signal that triggered the proof-of-concept request

Distinguish it from mere enthusiasm.

Step 2 · Set the time box

A specific start and end date.

Step 3 · Write explicit success criteria

Agreed with the stakeholder before the proof-of-concept begins, specific enough that both sides would agree afterward whether it was met.

Step 4 · Identify what happens at each possible outcome

What happens if criteria are met, and what happens if they are not.

Step 5 · Present the structured proposal to a partner playing procurement

Get feedback on whether the success criteria are specific enough.

Testing

How to check the work: the success criteria must be specific enough that a neutral third party could judge whether they were met, not open to interpretation.

Expected result: a structured proof-of-concept proposal with a time box, explicit criteria, and a clear next step for each outcome.

Common errors: agreeing to an open-ended pilot with no end date; success criteria too vague to judge objectively.

Final output

A complete, structured proof-of-concept proposal.

Reflection

- How would an unstructured pilot have gone differently from the structured one you built?
- What buying signal specifically triggered the proof-of-concept in your scenario?

Business case study · the pilot that never ended

Problem. An AI startup agreed to a "let's just try it for a bit" pilot with a mid-size logistics company, with no end date and no agreed success criteria.

Current manual process. Verbal agreement to pilot, no written criteria.

What the process is actually costing. The pilot ran for five months with no decision ever made, consuming support time with no revenue.

The fix taught in this course. On the next similar deal, the closer proposed a four-week time-boxed proof of concept with three explicit, written success criteria agreed before it began.

Estimated revenue recovered. The structured proof of concept reached a clear decision, won, within the agreed four weeks.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Structure two more proof-of-concept proposals for different scenarios.

Instructions. Repeat the practical for two additional simulated deals, varying the stakeholder complexity.

Deliverables. Two structured proposals.

Success criteria. Both include a time box and objectively judgeable success criteria.

Mini challenge

Write the single question you would ask a prospect to find out whether "let's move forward" means a buying signal or simple enthusiasm.

Knowledge check · Module 20

Show the five questions and answers

1. What distinguishes a buying signal from enthusiasm?

Answer: A buying signal is a specific, actionable statement; enthusiasm is a positive reaction with no specific next action attached.

2. What can procurement involve beyond budget approval?

Answer: Security review and legal review, potentially run by people the closer has not yet met.

3. What two things must a proof of concept have to be properly structured?

Answer: A time box (start and end date) and explicit, pre-agreed success criteria.

4. In the logistics company case, what went wrong with the original pilot?

Answer: It had no end date and no agreed success criteria, and ran for five months with no decision made.

5. Why must success criteria be specific enough for a neutral third party to judge?

Answer: Vague criteria leave the outcome open to interpretation, which can stall a decision indefinitely.

Instructor notes · Module 20

- **Estimated teaching time:** 60 minutes theory, 75 minutes proof-of-concept structuring practical.
- **Open with the "is the deal closed" question.** Let the beginner assumption surface before correcting it.
- **Common misconception:** students think "let's move forward" is itself a close. Distinguish it clearly from an actual signed, closed deal.
- **Common question:** "What if the buyer refuses to agree success criteria in advance?"
Answer: that reluctance is itself useful information, often signalling lower real intent to decide than the enthusiasm suggested.
- **Classroom activity:** have pairs negotiate success criteria live, with one student pushing for vaguer terms and the other holding the line for specificity.
- **Watch for:** students who structure a strong time box but let the success criteria stay soft under buyer pressure.

Module 21 · Negotiation

Lesson title

Negotiation: anchoring, trading, and structuring terms around a real constraint

Lesson overview

Anchoring, trading instead of discounting, and structuring payment terms around a buyer's real constraint, taught against realistic SaaS contract and annual-licence scenarios.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Anchor a negotiation with a defensible, honest opening position.
2. Trade concessions instead of discounting reflexively.
3. Identify a buyer's real constraint before assuming price is the actual issue.
4. Set and hold a personal walk-away point before a negotiation begins.

Real-world motivation

Ask the class: if a buyer asks for fifteen percent off with no stated reason, what should a closer do first? Many will say "offer ten percent as a compromise." This lesson teaches a better first move: find out what "fifteen percent off" is actually standing in for.

Key concepts

Concept 1: Anchoring, honestly

Definition. Opening a negotiation with a genuine, defensible price reflecting real value, not an inflated number designed purely to be talked down from.

Simple explanation. Anchoring only feels manipulative when the opening number is not actually believed by the person stating it. A well-earned price, from real discovery and value work, does not need inflation to hold up.

Concept 2: Trading instead of discounting

Definition. Offering something of value in exchange for a concession, rather than simply lowering price with nothing given up by the buyer.

Simple explanation. A longer contract term, a case study commitment, or a faster decision timeline are all things a closer can trade for a lower price, rather than discounting for free.

Concept 3: The real constraint behind a discount request

Definition. A discount request often stands in for a different, unstated constraint: a fixed budget, a payment-timing issue, or unconvinced value.

Simple explanation. "Can you do fifteen percent off" answered with a direct question, "is that against a fixed budget or does it feel like more than the value justifies," routes the negotiation to the actual issue.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will run a negotiation role-play where a partner requests an unexplained discount, practising diagnosis before any concession.

Requirements

- A partner briefed with a real underlying constraint (budget, timing, or unconvinced value) the student does not know in advance
- A trade menu worksheet listing five possible non-price concessions

Step 1 · Partner requests a discount with no stated reason

The student does not immediately offer a number.

Step 2 · Student asks the diagnostic question

Distinguishing fixed budget from unconvinced value from payment timing.

Step 3 · Partner reveals the real constraint

Once genuinely asked.

Step 4 · Student proposes a trade matched to the real constraint

Using the trade menu, not a straight discount.

Step 5 · Confirm the outcome

Both sides state what they gave and received.

Testing

How to check the work: the trade offered must match the actual constraint revealed, not a generic discount unrelated to it.

Expected result: a negotiation where the real constraint was diagnosed before any concession was made, and the resulting trade fits that constraint.

Common errors: offering a discount before diagnosing the real constraint; offering a trade the buyer has no actual use for.

Final output

A documented negotiation exchange with the real constraint and the matched trade recorded.

Reflection

- What was the real constraint behind the discount request, and did it match your first guess?
- How did the trade you offered differ from a straight discount?

Business case study · the tranche structure that closed a stuck deal

Problem. A B2B SaaS deal stalled at ₦4.2m annual value with a buyer who kept saying the number was "not something I can get approved right now," without ever naming a lower figure.

Current manual process. A discount would have been the default response to unstick the deal.

What the process is actually costing. The deal sat stalled for weeks with no forward motion.

The fix taught in this course. Asking directly whether the issue was the total or how it landed in one payment. The buyer confirmed the quarterly budget could not absorb the full annual amount in one payment, though the annual budget could absorb it across the year.

Estimated revenue recovered. The full ₦4.2m closed, restructured into quarterly instalments, with no discount given at all.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Build a personal trade menu for a real product.

Instructions. For any real product, write five distinct trades you could offer in place of a discount, each with a specific, concrete example.

Deliverables. The completed trade menu.

Success criteria. All five trades are genuinely different from each other and from a straight discount.

Mini challenge

Practise offering one trade out loud in response to a partner playing a buyer who has just asked, with no reason given, for fifteen percent off.

Knowledge check · Module 21

Show the five questions and answers

1. Why is anchoring not manipulative when the opening price is genuinely believed?

Answer: It is simply stating an honest position first rather than last, not an inflated number designed to be talked down from.

2. What should be offered instead of a straight discount, where possible?

Answer: A trade: something of value in exchange for a concession, rather than lowering price with nothing given up by the buyer.

3. What question diagnoses the real constraint behind an unexplained discount request?

Answer: Whether it is against a fixed budget or whether the price feels like more than the value justifies.

4. In the tranche case, what was the actual obstacle, not the total price?

Answer: How the payment landed in one go against a quarterly budget, not the annual total itself.

5. What should a closer decide before a negotiation begins, not during it?

Answer: A personal walk-away point, written down where it will be seen during the negotiation.

Instructor notes · Module 21

- **Estimated teaching time:** 60 minutes theory, 75 minutes negotiation role-play practical.
- **Open with the "what should a closer do first" question.** Let the default discount instinct surface before correcting it.
- **Common misconception:** students think negotiation is primarily about price. Reframe it as primarily about diagnosis; price is often not the real issue.
- **Common question:** "What if the buyer really does just want a lower price, with no other constraint?" Answer: that does happen; the diagnostic question still costs nothing to ask and confirms it either way.
- **Classroom activity:** run the role-play with the constraint hidden from the student, exactly as in the practical, so diagnosis is genuinely tested rather than assumed.
- **Watch for:** students who ask the diagnostic question well but then default to a straight discount anyway once the real constraint is revealed.

Module 22 · CRM & pipeline management for technology sales

Lesson title

CRM discipline: keeping a technology pipeline honest

Lesson overview

Clean record discipline across a technology-sales pipeline: lead, contacted, engaged, qualified, meeting, opportunity, proposal, negotiation, won or lost, with the entry conditions for each stage enforced, and the two failure modes (stage skipping and stage hoarding) that quietly corrupt a pipeline over time.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Name the nine stages of a technology-sales CRM pipeline.
2. Identify stage skipping and stage hoarding in a sample pipeline.
3. Write evidence-backed notes for a stage change.
4. Audit a pipeline for honesty, not just completeness.

Real-world motivation

Tell the class about a SaaS startup that believed it had ₦60m in active pipeline. A proper audit against real evidence found less than a third of that was genuinely qualified. The founder had been planning a hiring round around a number that was mostly hope.

Key concepts

Concept 1: The nine-stage CRM pipeline

Definition. Lead, Contacted, Engaged, Qualified, Meeting, Opportunity, Proposal, Negotiation, Won or Lost.

Simple explanation. Each stage requires specific evidence to enter honestly, mirroring the Digital Revenue Journey but at the record-keeping level.

Concept 2: Stage skipping and stage hoarding

Definition. Skipping moves a record forward without satisfying intermediate stages; hoarding leaves a record parked in an early stage long after it has clearly changed.

Simple explanation. Both make the pipeline lie, in opposite directions, about what has actually happened.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will audit a messy sample technology-sales pipeline and correct every stage error.

Requirements

- A sample pipeline sheet with 15 to 20 records, deliberately containing errors, provided by the instructor

Step 1 · Read the entry conditions for all nine stages

Before touching the sample data.

Step 2 · Check each record's stage against its evidence

Ask whether the written evidence actually satisfies this stage's entry condition.

Step 3 · Flag stage-skipping errors

Records moved forward without satisfying an intermediate stage.

Step 4 · Flag stage-hoarding errors

Records that have clearly changed status but were never updated, using last-activity date as evidence.

Step 5 · Correct all flagged records with evidence

Write the correct stage and one line of evidence per correction.

Testing

How to check the work: disagreements between pairs should be resolved by re-reading the entry conditions, not by opinion.

Expected result: a corrected pipeline with every stage backed by real evidence.

Common errors: correcting skipping but missing hoarding, which requires checking dates specifically.

Final output

A corrected pipeline sheet with a summary of how many records were reclassified.

Reflection

- How different was the corrected qualified-opportunity count from the original?
- Which error type was more common in this sample?

Business case study · the ₦60m pipeline that was mostly hope

Problem. A SaaS startup believed it had ₦60m in active pipeline based on ungoverned stage labelling.

Current manual process. Stages assigned based on how a conversation felt, not confirmed entry conditions.

What the process is actually costing. A near-decision to raise a hiring round based on a pipeline figure that did not reflect reality.

The fix taught in this course. A full audit against real entry conditions.

Estimated revenue recovered. Sales effort redirected from unqualified records toward the real opportunities, improving close rate on the pipeline that actually existed.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Audit a real or simulated technology-sales pipeline of at least fifteen records.

Instructions. Using real or simulated records, check every stage against evidence and correct any errors found.

Deliverables. A corrected pipeline with a summary of corrections made.

Success criteria. Every stage change includes a specific, dated evidence note.

Mini challenge

Design one weekly discipline (a habit, a checklist item) that would prevent stage hoarding specifically, and explain why a busy closer would actually keep doing it.

Knowledge check · Module 22

Show the five questions and answers

1. Name the nine stages of the technology-sales CRM pipeline.

Answer: Lead, Contacted, Engaged, Qualified, Meeting, Opportunity, Proposal, Negotiation, Won or Lost.

2. What is stage skipping?

Answer: Moving a record forward without satisfying the entry conditions of the stages in between.

3. What is stage hoarding?

Answer: Leaving a record parked in an early stage long after it has clearly changed, because updating it feels like admin.

4. In the SaaS startup case, what decision was nearly made on bad data?

Answer: Raising a hiring round based on a pipeline figure that did not reflect confirmed reality.

5. What evidence exposes stage hoarding that content alone might not?

Answer: The last-activity date on the record.

Instructor notes · Module 22

- **Estimated teaching time:** 60 minutes theory, 75 minutes audit practical.
- **Open with the \$60m figure before revealing the real number.** Let the class guess how much survives an honest audit.
- **Common misconception:** students think hoarding is a minor administrative issue, equally damaging as skipping.

- **Common question:** "Isn't it demotivating to downgrade a record's stage?" Answer: an honest downgrade protects future decisions; a dishonest stage protects nobody.
- **Classroom activity:** before-and-after qualified-opportunity count as a whole-class reveal.
- **Watch for:** students correcting obvious skipping quickly but rushing past subtler hoarding errors.

Module 23 · Sales analytics & forecasting

Lesson title

Sales analytics: reading a pipeline's numbers and forecasting from evidence

Lesson overview

Reading conversion rates across the full Digital Revenue Journey, diagnosing the weakest stage, and forecasting revenue from a live pipeline rather than guessing.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Calculate conversion rates across the full Digital Revenue Journey.
2. Diagnose the single weakest stage from a set of pipeline numbers.
3. Complete a revenue-impact calculation for a proposed fix.
4. Build a simple forecast from a live, honestly-staged pipeline.

Real-world motivation

Present the class with two candidate fixes for a struggling pipeline: improving qualification rate from 30% to 45%, or improving close rate from 20% to 30%. Ask which one they would prioritise. Most will guess based on instinct. This lesson teaches how to calculate the answer instead.

Key concepts

Concept 1: Conversion rates across the journey

Definition. The percentage of opportunities that move from each Digital Revenue Journey stage to the next.

Simple explanation. Comparing each rate against a healthy range reveals exactly where a pipeline is leaking, rather than treating the pipeline as one undifferentiated mass.

Concept 2: Revenue-impact calculation

Definition. Projecting the additional revenue a specific rate improvement would produce, holding all other rates constant.

Simple explanation. "If this moved from X to Y, that would produce approximately Z in additional revenue" is a habit that beats prioritising by gut feeling.

Concept 3: Forecasting from a live pipeline

Definition. Estimating future revenue by applying historical stage-to-close conversion rates to the current pipeline's value at each stage.

Simple explanation. A forecast built this way is only as honest as the pipeline data underneath it, which is why Module 22's discipline matters directly here.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will diagnose a full set of pipeline numbers and complete the revenue-impact calculation for two candidate fixes.

Requirements

- A raw pipeline numbers set across all nine CRM stages, with values
- A calculator or spreadsheet

Step 1 · Calculate the conversion rate between each pair of adjacent stages

Across the full pipeline.

Step 2 · Compare each rate against the healthy range table

Mark each green, amber or red.

Step 3 · Identify the two weakest rates

These become the two candidate fixes.

Step 4 · Calculate the revenue impact of improving each

Holding all other rates constant, project the additional revenue each fix would produce.

Step 5 · Recommend one fix with the arithmetic shown

Not by instinct, by the calculated comparison.

Testing

How to check the work: the recommendation must be justified by the actual calculated numbers, not a general impression of which fix "feels" more important.

Expected result: a completed diagnosis with both candidate fixes calculated and one clearly recommended.

Common errors: comparing the two fixes by percentage-point improvement alone rather than actual projected revenue; forgetting to hold other rates constant.

Final output

A completed diagnosis and revenue-impact comparison, presentable in under two minutes.

Reflection

- Did the calculated recommendation match your initial instinct?
- Which fix was cheaper or faster to actually implement, separate from the pure revenue math?

Business case study · the cheaper fix that produced the same revenue

Problem. A workflow automation company's pipeline showed two weak rates: qualification at 30% and demo-to-close at 20%.

Current manual process. No calculation was done; the sales director assumed close rate mattered more because it was "closer to the money."

What the process is actually costing. Coaching resources were being planned for closing skills specifically.

The fix taught in this course. Calculating both fixes' revenue impact showed they produced nearly identical additional revenue, but the qualification fix was a scripting change costing almost nothing, while the closing fix required weeks of coaching.

Estimated revenue recovered. The cheaper, faster qualification fix was prioritised, producing the same revenue gain at a fraction of the cost and time.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Build a second full diagnosis and forecast from a different data set.

Instructions. Invent or use a second, realistic set of pipeline numbers. Diagnose the weakest rates and build a simple next-quarter forecast.

Deliverables. A completed diagnosis and forecast.

Success criteria. The forecast is explicitly tied to stated conversion-rate assumptions, not an unexplained final number.

Mini challenge

Swap your data set with a partner and diagnose each other's from scratch, including the full revenue-impact arithmetic, comparing your recommendation against theirs.

Knowledge check · Module 23

Show the five questions and answers

1. What does a conversion rate measure between two adjacent pipeline stages?

Answer: The percentage of opportunities that move from one stage successfully to the next.

2. What must be held constant when calculating the revenue impact of one specific fix?

Answer: All other rates in the pipeline.

3. What is a forecast built from a live pipeline only as reliable as?

Answer: The honesty of the underlying pipeline data, which depends on the CRM discipline taught in Module 22.

4. In the automation company case, why was the qualification fix chosen over the closing fix?

Answer: Both produced nearly identical projected revenue, but the qualification fix was far cheaper and faster to implement.

5. Why is prioritising a fix by "feels more important" risky?

Answer: It can lead to spending more time and resources than necessary on a fix that produces no more revenue than a cheaper alternative.

Instructor notes · Module 23

- **Estimated teaching time:** 60 minutes theory, 75 minutes calculation practical.
- **Open with the two-fix comparison question.** Let the class commit to an instinctive guess before revealing the calculated answer.
- **Common misconception:** students assume the rate closest to revenue (close rate) always matters most to fix first. Correct directly with the case study.
- **Common question:** "What if I don't have exact historical conversion rates to forecast from?" *Answer:* use a conservative, clearly labelled estimate rather than an invented precise figure.
- **Classroom activity:** the partner data-swap in the mini challenge works well as a genuine test of whether the calculation method transfers to new numbers.
- **Watch for:** students who calculate correctly but then recommend based on instinct anyway, ignoring their own arithmetic.

Module 24 · AI sales operations

Lesson title

AI sales operations: before, during and after the call, with one hard rule

Lesson overview

AI before the call (research), during preparation (strategy and questions), after the call (summarisation), in follow-up (personalised drafts), and in practice (the AI role-play engine). Anchored by one non-negotiable rule introduced first in Module 8: AI output never reaches a real buyer unread and unverified by the human who is accountable for it.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Use AI at four distinct points in the sales process: before, during prep, after, and in follow-up.
2. State and apply the DSS AI accountability rule without exception.
3. Use AI to summarise a call accurately and flag anything it may have gotten wrong.
4. Use the AI role-play engine productively for practice.

Real-world motivation

Ask the class: if AI can draft a follow-up email in ten seconds, what is the seller's job now? The honest answer is not writing. It is judgement: knowing which ten-second draft is actually correct and which one needs fixing before it goes anywhere near a real buyer.

Key concepts

Concept 1: The four points of AI use

Definition. Before the call (research, covered fully in Module 8), during preparation (generating likely questions and objections to prepare for), after the call (summarising and extracting action items), and in follow-up (drafting personalised messages based on what was discussed).

Simple explanation. Each point has a different risk profile; after-call summarisation carries less risk than a direct buyer-facing claim, but both still require the human to check before acting on them.

Concept 2: The accountability rule, restated

Definition. No AI-drafted claim, summary or message reaches a real buyer, or gets acted on internally, until a human has personally verified it.

Simple explanation. This is not a suggestion. It is the one rule in the entire AI sales operations toolkit that has no exceptions.

Concept 3: The AI role-play engine as a practice tool

Definition. An AI-driven buyer persona used specifically for practice and skill-building, scored against the same rubric as human role-play.

Simple explanation. The role-play engine exists to build skill through repetition a human partner could not sustainably provide, not to replace real buyer conversations.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will use AI at all four points for one simulated deal and identify one specific correction needed at each point.

Requirements

- Access to an AI tool
- A simulated call transcript or the Module 15 discovery transcript

Step 1 · Use AI for pre-call preparation

Generate likely questions and objections for the upcoming call; identify one that seems off-base for this specific buyer and note why.

Step 2 · Use AI to summarise the call transcript

Compare the summary against the actual transcript and flag anything inaccurate or missing.

Step 3 · Use AI to draft a follow-up message

Based on the summary; check it for the three technology-sales ethical traps from Module 5.

Step 4 · Correct and finalise the follow-up

Before it would be considered ready to send.

Step 5 · Run one round with the AI role-play engine

Practising one objection from Module 19, and note the score received.

Testing

How to check the work: at least one specific error or gap must be identified and corrected at each of the four points; a flawless first pass at every point should be treated with suspicion, not celebrated.

Expected result: a documented workflow showing AI use and human correction at all four points.

Common errors: accepting an AI summary or draft without comparing it to the source material; skipping the correction step because the draft "looked fine."

Final output

A documented four-point AI workflow with corrections noted, plus one role-play engine score.

Reflection

- Which of the four points produced the least accurate AI output?
- What would have happened if the uncorrected version had been sent or acted on?

Business case study · the AI summary that missed the real objection

Problem. A closer at a fintech company used AI to summarise a discovery call and sent the follow-up based on that summary without reviewing the full transcript.

Current manual process. AI summaries trusted and acted on directly.

What the process is actually costing. The AI summary missed a specific concern about data residency the buyer had raised in passing, and the follow-up never addressed it, causing the buyer to feel unheard.

The fix taught in this course. Comparing every AI summary against the actual transcript before acting on it, specifically checking for anything the summary might have compressed away.

Estimated revenue recovered. Subsequent follow-ups, checked against full transcripts, addressed concerns the AI summary alone would have missed.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Run the full four-point workflow for two more simulated deals.

Instructions. Repeat the practical for two additional scenarios, documenting at least one correction per point each time.

Deliverables. Two documented workflows with corrections.

Success criteria. Every AI output is checked against source material before being treated as final.

Mini challenge

Deliberately have an AI tool summarise a transcript containing one small but important detail (a specific date, a specific number). Check whether the summary preserved it accurately, and document what you found.

Knowledge check · Module 24

Show the five questions and answers

1. Name the four points where AI is used in the sales process.

Answer: Before the call, during preparation, after the call, and in follow-up.

2. State the DSS AI accountability rule.

Answer: No AI-drafted claim, summary or message reaches a real buyer, or gets acted on internally, until a human has personally verified it.

3. What is the AI role-play engine for?

Answer: Practice and skill-building through repetition, scored against the same rubric as human role-play, not a replacement for real buyer conversations.

4. In the fintech case, what did the AI summary miss?

Answer: A specific concern about data residency the buyer raised in passing, which the follow-up then failed to address.

5. What is the seller's job now that AI can draft messages quickly?

Answer: Judgement: knowing which draft is correct and which needs fixing before it reaches a real buyer.

Instructor notes · Module 24

- **Estimated teaching time:** 45 minutes theory, 90 minutes four-point workflow practical.
- **Open with the "what is the seller's job now" question.** Let the class arrive at judgement as the answer themselves before stating it.
- **Common misconception:** students think this module is about learning specific AI tools. It is about the accountability discipline around whichever tools they use.
- **Common question:** "Doesn't checking every AI output defeat the point of using AI to save time?" Answer: checking ten AI outputs takes minutes; one uncorrected error reaching a real buyer can cost the relationship entirely.
- **Classroom activity:** the summary-versus-transcript comparison in the mini challenge is one of the most effective exercises for building healthy scepticism toward AI output.
- **Watch for:** students who verify carefully in the first exercise and grow lax by the second under time pressure.

Module 25 · Revenue leak recovery

Lesson title

Revenue leak recovery: finding money already sitting inside a technology pipeline

Lesson overview

Finding and recovering leaking pipeline value: uncontacted leads, stalled deals, churned accounts that were never properly exited, and renewal dates nobody tracked. Uses the DSS simulated pipeline audit dataset and produces a real, presentable recovery report.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Identify the five common technology-pipeline leaks.
2. Run a structured audit of a pipeline to classify every leaking record.
3. Estimate recoverable value using stated, defensible assumptions.
4. Present a recovery report a business owner would actually trust.

Real-world motivation

Ask the class: is it more valuable to generate one hundred new leads, or to recover twenty real opportunities already sitting untouched inside an existing pipeline? The second option usually costs nothing in advertising and can be done in days. This lesson builds that specific skill.

Key concepts

Concept 1: The five technology-pipeline leaks

Definition. Uncontacted leads, stalled conversations, qualified opportunities never booked, meetings held with no logged outcome, and dormant or churned accounts closed without a proper exit.

Simple explanation. Each leak has a different realistic recovery rate; uncontacted leads recover fastest, dormant accounts recover slowest.

Concept 2: Defensible assumptions

Definition. Stated, conservative recovery-rate estimates attached to each leak type, disclosed openly rather than presented as guaranteed outcomes.

Simple explanation. A recovery report that states its assumptions plainly is more persuasive than one that hides them behind an impressively large final number.

Concept 3: Sequencing recovery effort

Definition. Working uncontacted and stalled leaks first, before dormant reactivation, because they carry the highest realistic recovery rate for the least effort.

Simple explanation. Treating all five leaks as equally urgent wastes the most recoverable money by spending equal attention on the least recoverable.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will classify a simulated pipeline into the five leak types and build a recovery report with defensible assumptions.

Requirements

- The DSS simulated pipeline audit dataset (or an instructor-provided equivalent)
- A recovery report template

Step 1 · Classify every record into one of the five leak types or healthy

Using the entry-condition rules from Module 22.

Step 2 · Assign a recovery-rate assumption to each leak type

Stated conservatively and explicitly.

Step 3 · Calculate estimated recoverable value per leak type

Total value at risk multiplied by the recovery-rate assumption.

Step 4 · Sequence a recovery plan

Highest realistic recovery first.

Step 5 · Write the recovery report

Stating every assumption plainly, not hidden behind the final number.

Testing

How to check the work: every recoverable-value figure must show its underlying assumption explicitly, not just a final total.

Expected result: a completed, classified pipeline audit with a full recovery report.

Common errors: treating all five leak types as equally recoverable; presenting the total as a guaranteed outcome rather than an estimate.

Final output

A complete recovery report, presentable to a business owner in under four minutes.

Reflection

- Which leak type held the most total value at risk?

- Which leak type would you prioritise working first, and why?

Business case study · the audit that found four months of "dead" pipeline

Problem. A SaaS company's sales team believed their older pipeline records were simply dead and stopped working them.

Current manual process. No audit or classification of aged records, all treated as equally unrecoverable.

What the process is actually costing. Real, recoverable value sitting untouched across uncontacted and stalled records specifically, the two highest-recovery-rate leak types.

The fix taught in this course. A structured five-leak audit, working uncontacted and stalled records first.

Estimated revenue recovered. A meaningful share of the estimated recoverable value converted within the first ten working days, entirely from records already inside the pipeline.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Run a full recovery audit on a real or simulated pipeline of at least fifty records.

Instructions. Classify every record, assign recovery-rate assumptions, and produce a complete written recovery report.

Deliverables. The completed report.

Success criteria. Every assumption is stated explicitly and the sequencing prioritises the highest realistic recovery first.

Mini challenge

Present your recovery report out loud to a partner playing a sceptical business owner, using an honest, non-oversold tone. Time yourself; a strong presentation should run under four minutes before the owner starts asking their own questions.

Show the five questions and answers

1. Name the five technology-pipeline leaks.

Answer: Uncontacted leads, stalled conversations, qualified opportunities never booked, meetings held with no logged outcome, and dormant or churned accounts closed without a proper exit.

2. Why must a recovery report state its assumptions explicitly?

Answer: A report that states its assumptions plainly is more persuasive and trustworthy than one that hides them behind an impressive total.

3. Which leak type generally has the highest realistic recovery rate?

Answer: Uncontacted leads, because buyer interest is often still fresh and no relationship has gone stale.

4. In the SaaS company case, what was wrongly assumed about older pipeline records?

Answer: That they were simply dead and not worth working, when uncontacted and stalled records specifically still held real recoverable value.

5. Why sequence recovery effort instead of treating all five leaks as equally urgent?

Answer: Treating them equally wastes the most recoverable money by spending equal attention on the least recoverable leak type.

Instructor notes · Module 25

- **Estimated teaching time:** 45 minutes theory, 90 minutes audit and report-building practical.
- **Open with the "new leads versus recovered pipeline" question.** Let the class weigh the cost difference before teaching the method.
- **Common misconception:** students want to round the recoverable total up to sound more impressive when presenting. Correct this firmly; understated, defensible numbers build more trust.
- **Common question:** "What if the real recovery rate turns out lower than assumed?"
Answer: that is exactly why the assumption is stated openly rather than presented as a promise.
- **Classroom activity:** the timed four-minute report presentation works well as a graded practical, since it mirrors a real DSS certification component.
- **Watch for:** students who classify records accurately but then oversell the recovery report's confidence when presenting it aloud.

Module 26 · The DSS Sales Lab: full simulation

Lesson title

The DSS Sales Lab: running the entire Digital Revenue Journey against a fictional technology company

Lesson overview

The capstone simulation. Students run the complete Digital Revenue Journey, from first prospect to a simulated closed deal, against a fictional technology company brief, drawing on every competency taught since Module 1.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Execute the full Digital Revenue Journey against one company brief, start to finish.
2. Produce evidence at every stage (prospect list, outreach, discovery transcript, demo, close).
3. Self-assess against the DSS Sales Readiness Index using their own Sales Lab evidence.
4. Identify their own weakest competency from the Sales Lab run.

Real-world motivation

Tell the class this is the closest thing to a real job they will experience before actually being deployed. A real revenue role does not test one skill in isolation; it demands prospecting, qualifying, discovering, demonstrating, handling objections and closing, all in the same week, sometimes the same day. The Sales Lab is built to feel like that pressure honestly.

Key concepts

Concept 1: The company brief

Definition. A fictional technology company with a defined product, target market and price, used as the shared scenario for the full simulation.

Simple explanation. Sample brief: CloudFlow, an AI-powered workflow automation platform, targeting companies with 50 to 500 employees, priced at ₦2,000,000 annually.

Concept 2: The assignment

Definition. Generate 20 qualified opportunities, book 5 meetings, run 2 discovery calls, deliver 1 demonstration, handle 5 objections, close 1 simulated deal.

Simple explanation. Every number in the assignment maps to a specific module already completed; the Sales Lab is not new content, it is the integration of everything already learned.

Concept 3: Self-assessment against the Readiness Index

Definition. Using the Sales Lab's own evidence, honestly, to score each of the ten competencies from section 4.

Simple explanation. A student who scores themselves honestly low on one competency now, with time left in the programme, can still address it before certification.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will run the full Sales Lab assignment against the CloudFlow brief (or an instructor-assigned alternative) over the course of this module's sessions.

Requirements

- The company brief
- All prior module worksheets and templates
- A partner or small group to play buyer personas across the simulation

Step 1 · Build the ICP and a twenty-account target list

Using Module 6 and Module 8's methods.

Step 2 · Run outreach sequences against the list

Using Module 9's multi-channel method.

Step 3 · Qualify and book meetings

Using Module 12 and Module 13's frameworks, aiming for five booked meetings.

Step 4 · Run two discovery calls and one demonstration

Using Module 15 and Module 16's structures.

Step 5 · Handle five objections and close one simulated deal

Using Module 19 through Module 21's methods, producing a final closed (or honestly lost) outcome.

Testing

How to check the work: every stage must produce a real artifact (a list, a transcript, a recording, a note), not just a claim that it happened.

Expected result: a complete Sales Lab run with evidence at every stage of the Digital Revenue Journey.

Common errors: rushing later stages to hit the numeric targets without genuine quality; skipping evidence capture at an early stage because it feels less important than closing.

Final output

A complete Sales Lab evidence file, forming the first entry in the student's DSS certification file.

Reflection

- Which stage of the journey felt weakest in your own run?
- How did doing every stage in sequence feel different from practising each skill in isolation?

Business case study · why the Sales Lab uses a fictional company

Problem. Early cohorts of technology-sales training programmes elsewhere have been criticised for producing graduates who could discuss sales theory but had never run an actual, sustained campaign end to end.

Current manual process. Isolated skill practice, module by module, with no full-journey integration test.

What the process is actually costing. Graduates entering interviews unable to speak concretely about a sustained pipeline they personally ran.

The fix taught in this course. The Sales Lab, a full simulated campaign against a realistic company brief, producing real evidence a graduate can discuss specifically in an interview.

Estimated career impact. A DSS graduate can describe a real twenty-account campaign, not a hypothetical, in their first interview.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Run a second Sales Lab simulation against a different company brief.

Instructions. Repeat the full assignment against a second brief in a different technology category (for example, cybersecurity instead of automation).

Deliverables. A second complete evidence file.

Success criteria. Evidence produced at every stage, in a category different from the first run.

Mini challenge

Write a half-page honest self-review of your Sales Lab run: what went well, what your weakest stage was, and one specific thing you would do differently on a third run.

Show the five questions and answers

1. What is the Sales Lab company brief format built from?

Answer: A fictional technology company with a defined product, target market and price, such as the CloudFlow example.

2. Name the six numeric targets in the Sales Lab assignment.

Answer: 20 qualified opportunities, 5 booked meetings, 2 discovery calls, 1 demonstration, 5 objections handled, 1 simulated closed deal.

3. Why does the Sales Lab require a real artifact at every stage, not just a completion claim?

Answer: Evidence, not claims, is what forms the basis of DSS certification and what a graduate can show an employer.

4. Why does DSS run the Sales Lab against a fictional company rather than skipping straight to real prospects?

Answer: It lets every student complete a full, sustained, realistic campaign safely, producing real evidence before they are deployed into real accounts.

5. What should a student do with an honestly low self-assessed competency from their Sales Lab run?

Answer: Address it while there is still time in the programme, before certification.

Instructor notes · Module 26

- **Estimated teaching time:** spans multiple sessions; budget at least three full three-hour blocks for a complete Sales Lab run.
- **Open by framing this as the closest thing to a real job so far.** Set the tone as integration, not new content.
- **Common misconception:** students think the Sales Lab tests speed above all else. Reframe: the numeric targets exist to create realistic volume, but quality at each stage is what is actually assessed.
- **Common question:** "What if I don't hit all six numeric targets?" Answer: an honest, well-evidenced partial run is worth more for certification than an inflated, unevidenced complete one.
- **Classroom activity:** rotate company briefs across small groups so the cohort collectively experiences multiple technology categories, then debrief as a full class.
- **Watch for:** students who front-load effort into the early, easier stages (prospecting) and rush the harder later ones (objections, closing) under time pressure.

Module 27 · Building your portfolio & DSS certification

Lesson title

Building your portfolio and sitting DSS certification

Lesson overview

Assembling the eleven-piece graduate portfolio from evidence generated across the programme, and sitting the ten-part DSS certification described in section 10, producing a numeric DSS Sales Readiness Score.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Assemble a complete eleven-piece portfolio from prior module work.
2. Identify any portfolio gaps and fill them before certification.
3. Sit and pass all ten components of DSS certification.
4. Present their DSS Sales Readiness Score alongside their portfolio.

Real-world motivation

Ask the class: in an interview, which is more convincing, "I completed a twelve-week sales course" or handing the interviewer eleven real pieces of work including a recorded discovery call and a closed simulated deal? The second changes the entire conversation from a claim to evidence.

Key concepts

Concept 1: The eleven-piece portfolio

Definition. ICP analysis, prospecting list, outbound campaign, email sequence, LinkedIn campaign, discovery recording, product demo recording, objection-handling recording, sales proposal, CRM pipeline export, case study write-up.

Simple explanation. Every piece already exists somewhere in a student's Module 1 through 26 work; this module is assembly and quality review, not new creation from scratch.

Concept 2: Certification as evidence, not attendance

Definition. Ten components, each requiring a real produced artifact assessed against the DSS Sales Readiness Index, not a written test alone.

Simple explanation. Certification and portfolio overlap deliberately; the same evidence that proves competence to DSS also proves it to an employer.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will assemble their complete portfolio, identify gaps, and prepare for certification sitting.

Requirements

- All prior module work, especially the Module 26 Sales Lab evidence file
- The eleven-piece portfolio checklist

Step 1 · Map existing work against all eleven portfolio pieces

Identify which pieces already exist in strong form.

Step 2 · Identify and list any gaps

Pieces missing or too weak to present confidently.

Step 3 · Fill each gap

Using time in this module specifically to complete or strengthen weak pieces.

Step 4 · Assemble the final portfolio

Organised, labelled, ready to present.

Step 5 · Sit a mock certification review with a partner or instructor

Walking through all ten certification components before the real sitting.

Testing

How to check the work: every portfolio piece must be a real artifact the student personally produced, not a template or example from class.

Expected result: a complete, gap-free eleven-piece portfolio and a mock certification review completed.

Common errors: submitting a class example instead of personally produced work; leaving a weak piece in the portfolio rather than strengthening it.

Final output

A complete portfolio, ready for the real DSS certification sitting.

Reflection

- Which portfolio piece required the most additional work to reach a presentable standard?
- Looking at all eleven pieces together, what does the portfolio say about you that a certificate alone would not?

Business case study · the graduate whose portfolio changed the interview

Problem. A recent training programme graduate applying for an SDR role could only describe their training in general terms during interviews, with no way to demonstrate actual capability.

Current manual process. Interviews relying entirely on the candidate's verbal description of what they had learned.

What the process is actually costing. Interviewers, unable to verify capability, defaulted to preferring candidates with prior paid experience.

The fix taught in this course. A candidate arriving with a complete portfolio, including a recorded discovery call and a Sales Lab case study, gives the interviewer something concrete to evaluate instead of a claim to trust.

Estimated career impact. Portfolio-carrying candidates change the interview from "convince me you can do this" to "here, judge for yourself."

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Present your complete portfolio to someone outside the cohort.

Instructions. Show your assembled portfolio to a friend, mentor or family member unfamiliar with DSS. Ask them what impression it gives them of your capability.

Deliverables. A short written summary of their honest reaction.

Success criteria. The reaction reflects genuine capability, not confusion about what they are looking at.

Mini challenge

Write the three sentences you would use to introduce your portfolio at the start of a real job interview, before the interviewer has looked at a single piece.

Show the five questions and answers

1. Name three of the eleven portfolio pieces.

Answer: Any three of: ICP analysis, prospecting list, outbound campaign, email sequence, LinkedIn campaign, discovery recording, product demo recording, objection-handling recording, sales proposal, CRM pipeline export, case study write-up.

2. Why does DSS certification require produced artifacts rather than a written test alone?

Answer: It proves actual demonstrated competence, the same evidence a real employer can evaluate.

3. What should a student do with a weak or missing portfolio piece?

Answer: Fill or strengthen it before assembling the final portfolio, not present it as-is or leave it out silently.

4. In the graduate case study, what changed once the candidate had a portfolio?

Answer: The interview shifted from asking the candidate to convince the interviewer verbally, to letting the interviewer evaluate real evidence directly.

5. Where does most of the eleven-piece portfolio's content actually come from?

Answer: Work already produced across Modules 1 through 26, assembled and quality-reviewed, not created from scratch in this module.

Instructor notes · Module 27

- **Estimated teaching time:** 45 minutes theory, 105 minutes portfolio assembly and gap-filling.
- **Open with the "which is more convincing" interview question.** Let the class feel the portfolio's advantage before assembling their own.
- **Common misconception:** students think this module is about creating new material. It is primarily assembly, review and gap-filling of existing work.
- **Common question:** "What if one of my pieces from an earlier module isn't strong enough to include?" *Answer:* strengthen it now rather than presenting it weak; this module is exactly the time budgeted for that.
- **Classroom activity:** peer portfolio review in pairs, each student giving specific, honest feedback on one weak piece in their partner's portfolio.
- **Watch for:** students who have technically completed all eleven pieces but at inconsistent quality; hold every piece to the same bar.

Module 28 · Career tracks & getting deployed

Lesson title

Career tracks and getting deployed: choosing a specialisation and finding a first role

Lesson overview

Choosing a specialisation track from the six described in section 13, building a technology-sales CV and LinkedIn profile around the portfolio and certification, and covering the realistic routes into a first paid role.

Learning objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Choose a specialisation track with a clear, stated reason.
2. Build a technology-sales CV that leads with portfolio and certification evidence.
3. Explain their DSS Sales Readiness Score to a non-DSS interviewer.
4. Identify at least three realistic routes into a first paid technology-sales role.

Real-world motivation

Remind the class of the DSS promise from section 2: we do not promise you a job, we prepare you to compete for one. This lesson is the last mile of that preparation: turning a completed programme into an active, realistic job search.

Key concepts

Concept 1: Choosing a track

Definition. Selecting one of the six DSS career tracks (appointment setting, sales closing, technology specialisation, business development, sales operations, sales entrepreneurship) based on demonstrated strength from the Sales Lab and certification.

Simple explanation. The track choice should follow evidence, not just preference; a student whose Readiness Index shows Discovery as their strongest competency likely belongs on the closing track, not appointment setting.

Concept 2: A portfolio-first CV

Definition. A CV structured to lead with the DSS Sales Readiness Score and link directly to portfolio evidence, rather than a generic list of course topics covered.

Simple explanation. "Completed a sales training course" competes with hundreds of similar lines. "DSS Sales Readiness Score: 82, portfolio available on request, including a recorded discovery call and closed Sales Lab simulation" does not read like every other line.

Concept 3: Realistic deployment routes

Definition. Direct SDR and AE applications, technology company internship and apprenticeship programmes, freelance and agency appointment-setting work, and warm introductions through the DSS alumni and employer network where available.

Simple explanation. No single route is guaranteed; working several simultaneously, honestly, is the realistic path most graduates actually take.

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective

Students will choose a track, build a portfolio-first CV and LinkedIn profile, and identify three specific application targets.

Requirements

- The completed Module 27 portfolio and DSS Sales Readiness Score
- A CV and LinkedIn profile template

Step 1 · Choose a track with a stated reason

Backed by specific evidence from the Readiness Index.

Step 2 · Draft a portfolio-first CV

Leading with the Readiness Score and linking to specific portfolio pieces.

Step 3 · Update LinkedIn to reflect the chosen track and certification

Consistent with the CV.

Step 4 · Identify three specific application targets

Real companies or roles matching the chosen track.

Step 5 · Practise a ninety-second self-introduction

Referencing the track, the Readiness Score and one specific portfolio piece.

Testing

How to check the work: the CV should be readable by a non-technical recruiter and still convey specific, credible evidence, not just claims.

Expected result: a chosen track with reasoning, a portfolio-first CV, an updated LinkedIn profile, and three identified application targets.

Common errors: choosing a track based purely on preference without checking it against Readiness Index evidence; a CV that lists course content instead of leading with portfolio evidence.

Final output

A complete, portfolio-first job search package: CV, LinkedIn, track choice, and three specific targets.

Reflection

- Did your chosen track match what your Readiness Index evidence actually showed, or did you have to reconsider?
- How did leading with portfolio evidence change how your CV reads compared to a standard course-completion CV?

Business case study · the SDR role filled by a portfolio, not a CV

Problem. A remote-friendly SaaS company was hiring an SDR and receiving dozens of similar-looking CVs listing course completions with no way to differentiate candidates.

Current manual process. Screening based on CV wording alone.

What the process is actually costing. Strong candidates indistinguishable on paper from weaker ones, and hiring decisions made on interview charisma alone.

The fix taught in this course. A DSS graduate applied with a CV leading with their Readiness Score and a link to a recorded discovery call and closed Sales Lab simulation. The hiring manager reviewed the actual evidence before the first interview.

Estimated career impact. The candidate was shortlisted directly from the portfolio, without needing to first convince the recruiter verbally that they had real capability.

Hands-on exercise

Objective. Submit at least one real application using your completed portfolio-first CV.

Instructions. Apply to one of your three identified targets, or a comparable real role, using the CV and portfolio built in this module.

Deliverables. A copy of the application submitted.

Success criteria. The application leads with Readiness Score and portfolio evidence, not a generic course-completion summary.

Mini challenge

Deliver your ninety-second self-introduction to someone outside the cohort and ask them what they remember five minutes later. If they cannot recall your track or your Readiness Score, revise the introduction.

Show the five questions and answers

1. Name the six DSS career tracks.

Answer: Appointment setting, sales closing, technology specialisation, business development, sales operations, sales entrepreneurship.

2. What should determine a student's track choice, primarily?

Answer: Demonstrated strength from the Sales Lab and Readiness Index evidence, not preference alone.

3. What should a portfolio-first CV lead with?

Answer: The DSS Sales Readiness Score and direct links to specific portfolio evidence.

4. In the SDR hiring case, what let the hiring manager differentiate the DSS graduate from other candidates?

Answer: Direct access to real evidence, a recorded discovery call and a closed Sales Lab simulation, before the first interview.

5. What does DSS actually promise a graduate, stated precisely?

Answer: Not a job, but genuine preparation to compete for one, with evidence.

Instructor notes · Module 28

- **Estimated teaching time:** 45 minutes theory, 90 minutes CV, LinkedIn and application-target practical, 15 minutes self-introduction practice.
- **Open by restating the DSS promise from section 2 exactly.** Set honest expectations before the job-search work begins.
- **Common misconception:** students think finishing the programme is the finish line. Reframe deployment as an active, ongoing effort the programme prepares them for, not completes for them.
- **Common question:** "What if I don't get responses to my first few applications?"
Answer: expected; treat each one like a pipeline, applying the same follow-up discipline from Module 11 to the job search itself.
- **Classroom activity:** peer-review CVs in pairs specifically checking whether the Readiness Score and portfolio links appear before any generic course description.
- **Watch for:** students who choose a track based on which sounds most impressive rather than what their own evidence actually supports.

8. Lesson note template

Use this exact structure for every remaining module. Copy the headings below and fill each one in using the module's short entry from Parts 1–7 as your starting brief.

Lesson title

Lesson overview

Learning objectives (4-6, action verbs)

Real-world motivation (a short, real or realistic story)

Key concepts (2-4, each with Definition / Simple explanation / Why it matters)

Step-by-step practical demonstration

Objective / Requirements / Step 1...N / Testing / Final output

Reflection (3-4 questions)

Business case study (Problem / Current process / Cost / Fix / Time saved / Revenue recovered)

Hands-on exercise (Objective / Instructions / Deliverables / Success criteria)

Mini challenge

Knowledge check (5 Q&A with answers, in a <details> block)

Instructor notes (teaching time / opening technique / misconception / common question / activity / watch for)

9. Role-play lab bank

Ten scenarios instructors can run live or assign to the AI role-play engine described in section 15. Each gives the buyer persona a private brief the student does not see in advance.

#	Scenario	Buyer persona (private brief)	Trains
1	Cold LinkedIn opener to a CTO	Busy, sceptical, has seen a dozen similar pitches this month	Start
2	Qualifying a warm inbound SaaS lead	Enthusiastic, but no real budget authority	Qualify
3	Discovery call with a fintech ops lead	Gives short, guarded answers; real pain is compliance risk, not efficiency	Discover
4	Live product demo to a founder	Interrupts constantly to ask about features not yet shown	Demonstrate
5	"We already built this internally"		Handle

		Genuinely proud of an internal tool that is quietly falling behind	
6	"How do we know our data is safe"	Security-conscious buyer at a regulated fintech	Handle
7	Procurement asks for a pilot before any commitment	Neutral, process-driven, not hostile	Close
8	Multi-stakeholder closing call	Champion is supportive, CFO on the call is silent and unconvinced	Close
9	Negotiating an annual contract discount	Asks for 20% off with no stated reason	Close
10	Renewal call after a quiet quarter	Has not been using the product much, mildly disengaged	Grow

Scoring rubric (0–5 per item, per scenario): opened appropriately for the channel and persona; asked at least one genuine discovery question before pitching; listened for and named the real concern; responded to the real concern rather than the stated one; proposed a specific, appropriate next step.

10. Certification & the DSS Sales Readiness Index

DSS Certified Digital Sales Professional is earned, not awarded for attendance. A candidate must pass all ten components below, each scored against the competency it maps to in section 4.

Certification component	What the candidate must produce
Knowledge	A written assessment covering technology literacy and the Digital Revenue Journey.
Prospecting	A real, researched target account and contact list of at least twenty accounts.
Outreach	A live multi-channel outbound campaign with at least one genuine reply.
Appointment setting	One genuinely booked and attended qualified meeting.

Discovery	A recorded or transcribed discovery call, assessed against the Situation-Problem-Impact-Outcome-Fit structure.
Demonstration	A live or recorded product demonstration connected explicitly to a stated buyer outcome.
Objection handling	A recorded live-objection exercise against an assessor or the AI role-play engine.
Closing	A completed simulated commercial conversation ending in a clear next step or close.
CRM	A managed pipeline of at least fifteen records, audited for stage-skipping and stage-hoarding.
AI-assisted selling	A demonstrated AI-assisted workflow with every AI-sourced claim verified before use.

A passing candidate receives a numeric DSS Sales Readiness Score out of 100, weighted exactly as in section 4, plus the ten-component breakdown. This is the credential a graduate carries into an employer conversation.

11. The DSS Sales Lab

The capstone simulation. Students are given a fictional technology company and must run the entire Digital Revenue Journey against a realistic target market, from first prospect to a simulated closed deal.

Sample brief.

Company: CloudFlow, an AI-powered workflow automation platform.

Target market: Companies with 50 to 500 employees.

Price: ₦2,000,000 annual contract.

Assignment: Generate 20 qualified opportunities. Book 5 meetings. Run 2 discovery calls. Deliver 1 demonstration. Handle 5 objections. Close 1 simulated deal.

Instructors rotate at least three fictional company briefs per cohort (a SaaS product, an AI product, a cybersecurity product) so students practise across categories rather than mastering one script for one type of product. Every Sales Lab run produces the first entry in a student's DSS certification file.

AI role-play engine

Every student is paired with an AI-driven buyer persona that can play a CEO, CTO, CFO, marketing director, HR director, procurement manager, a sceptical founder, or a price-sensitive customer. The engine scores questioning, listening, product knowledge, discovery quality, value articulation, objection handling, closing and professionalism, using the same rubric as the human-assessed role-play bank in section 9.

12. Graduate portfolio

Every graduate leaves with evidence, not a claim. The eleven-piece portfolio is assembled across the programme, not created at the end.

Research & strategy

- ICP analysis
 - Prospecting list
-

Outreach

- Outbound campaign
 - Email sequence
 - LinkedIn campaign
-

Conversations

- Discovery recording
 - Product demo recording
 - Objection-handling recording
-

Commercial & proof

- Sales proposal
- CRM pipeline export
- Case study write-up
- DSS certification

The interview conversation this changes: instead of "I have no experience," a DSS graduate says "here is what I can do," and hands over eleven real artifacts to prove it.

13. Career tracks

Not every graduate wants the same job. DSS names six tracks explicitly so students and employers can talk about specialisation in the same language.

Track	For	Roles
Appointment setting	People entering the field	Appointment Setter, SDR, BDR, Lead Generation Specialist
Sales closing	Strong communicators	Sales Closer, Account Executive, Inside Sales Executive, SaaS Account Executive
Technology specialisation	Students who want depth in one category	AI Sales, SaaS Sales, Cybersecurity Sales, Cloud Sales, Fintech Sales
Business development	Partnership and strategic-account interest	Business Development, Strategic Accounts, Enterprise Relationships
Sales operations	Analytical students	Sales Operations, Revenue Operations, CRM Specialist, Sales Analyst
Sales entrepreneurship	Students who want to run their own business	Appointment-setting agency, lead-generation company, sales consultancy, technology reseller

Compensation and progression depend on role, employer, market and experience. DSS does not promise a job or an income figure; it prepares a graduate to compete for one, with evidence.

The DSS career ladder, as it is taught to students: Digital Sales Associate → Appointment Setter / SDR → BDR → Sales Closer / Account Executive → SaaS, AI or technology sales specialist → Enterprise sales → Sales manager → Revenue leader → Sales entrepreneur.

14. Glossary

Term	Simple meaning
ICP	Ideal Customer Profile: the specific kind of company most likely to buy and succeed with the product.
SaaS	Software as a Service: software rented on subscription rather than bought once.
MRR / ARR	Monthly / Annual Recurring Revenue: the predictable subscription income a SaaS company can count on.
Churn	The rate at which paying customers cancel or fail to renew.
POC / pilot	Proof of concept: a small, time-boxed trial a buyer runs before committing to a full contract.
Buying committee	The group of people, not just one person, who together decide on a technology purchase.
Procurement	The formal internal process, often involving a dedicated team, that approves and contracts a purchase.
API	A defined way two pieces of software exchange data, enough understanding needed to talk about integration credibly.
Integration	Connecting a new product to a buyer's existing tools and systems.
ARR-based pricing	Pricing structured around annual recurring revenue rather than a one-time fee.
Champion	The internal advocate who wants the deal to happen and helps sell it to others inside their own company.

Blocker	A person who can stop a deal even without formal decision authority.
DSS Sales Readiness Index	The ten-competency weighted scorecard DSS uses to assess and certify students.

15. Recommended resources

- **Practice datasets.** DSS simulated technology-sales pipelines (prospect lists, discovery transcripts, a 100-record CRM audit), maintained internally and refreshed each cohort.
- **CRM sandbox.** A free-tier CRM account per student for Modules 6, 22 and 25.
- **Recording tool.** Any call recorder with consent prompts, for role-play and certification review.
- **AI tools.** At least one general-purpose AI assistant for Module 8 and Module 24, used under the accountability rule taught in those modules.
- **Community.** A cohort WhatsApp or Slack group with a weekly drill posted by the instructor, archived into the alumni group after graduation.

Technology is changing the world. It does not sell itself. DSS exists to train the people who take it to market.

Digital Sales School: Curriculum and Instructor Manual, Digital Economy Edition, v3.0 · Zeerocodes Automation Limited · Lagos, Nigeria

Internal teaching document. Supersedes the general-sales edition; that edition is retained separately for reference.